I'm Right Where You Left Me

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/33302617.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply, Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), many OCs, many other characters' POVs

Additional Tags:
Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Light Angst, i think it's light, Eventual Happy Ending, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, will update tags as I go, Catra-centric (She-Ra), Adora-centric (She-Ra), Descriptions of Dissociation, description of panic attacks, mentions of depression, Shadow Weaver is a bitch, Catra is sort of a BAMF for a bit, Rated T for swearing, (and slight violence/blood)

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English

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Part 8 of Catra Applesauce Meowmeow

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I'm Right Where You Left Me

by AOS100

Summary

Catra didn’t want her revenge. She didn’t want to try and stumble her way back to a person that didn’t care about her the same way she had cared. She didn’t want to break her own heart any further. So she stayed. She stayed hidden in the woods, and then later moved to hide in Thaymor where everyone adopted her. But she never left. She stayed in the place where she could relive the most horrible moment of her life every day.

She stayed right where Adora had left her.

A Canon-Divergent AU told by the perspective of several villagers and by Catra’s own perspective, inspired by Taylor Swift’s “Right Where You Left Me” starting the moment that Adora and Catra separated in Thaymor. Because all of Taylor’s songs can fit Catradora. All of them.

Notes

I wrote this because even though all of Taylor's songs can fit Catradora, this one for some reason really hits me hard and I'm a sad little writer.

I don't own anything except all the little weird OC's, and I have no Beta.

See the end of the work for more notes

She's Gone

Right, when I felt the moment stop

Glass, shattered on the white cloth

Everybody moved on

I stayed there

Dust collected on my pinned up hair

They expected me to find somewhere

Some perspective

But I sat and stared

Right where

You left me

- Taylor Swift - Right Where You Left Me

She was gone.

Adora was gone and now Catra didn't know what to do. She couldn't go back to the Horde, the only reason she had ever stayed there was on her way, probably deep into the woods by now, and with her mission having failed, Catra wasn't going to be able to escape punishment.

Punishment that was no longer worth it to endure. Punishment she had only *ever* endured for one person.

She had no one, nowhere, because the only person she had ever cared about *left* , and the place she had spent her entire life in was a place she wouldn't go back to voluntarily.

After the dust had settled, and she watched Adora disappear into the Whispering woods, Catra herself went to hide there. She was a Horde soldier, she knew no matter what her intentions were, it was likely that the Horde was hated out in the real world. They had just destroyed this village, after all. So she waited.

She waited because she had no idea what to do, and even with only one thought in her mind, she knew there wasn't much she *could* do except mourn. Yes, that would do.

The people of Thaymor eventually returned to their destroyed homes, hours after they watched the Horde tanks and soldiers retreat. Small fires that hadn't spread were still flickering, and one

could hear the cries of children who didn’t understand why this had happened.

Truly, no one could understand how such evil, such cruelty could fall upon them in the waves of smoke and metal that came the innocent on this planet.

No one understood and yet it still happened. All they could do was hope their lives were spared, and when the glistening of metal helmets and crackling of electricity was gone, they would gather back together, scraping up the meager possessions they could find left.

It was almost common at this point, so common that it was no longer a surprise to hear of a village being burned to the ground for no fathomable reason, but there was something different this time.

A horde soldier had stayed behind. She had an unusual-looking uniform, but she had the standard requirements for any soldier to wear. Everyone knew what Horde soldiers looked like, it was unmistakable. She had emerged from the woods as well, a lost look in her eyes. She made no move to attack, and she paid people no mind as she walked by. It was such an unsettling sight, nobody even bothered to be angry.

She looked so blank, so empty. Even with her eyes being colored a more vibrant shade than any of the clothing around, the light in them was dimmed. Not quite gone, no she still had a bit of life in her- but the girl almost looked like she didn’t even want that.

A broken heart.

Katya could recognize it anywhere. In her 43 years of life, she had experienced it more than any one person should have. People, her sister most of all, told her she always fell too hard, too fast. She supposed it was true, for every time that she believed she had found the one, the person she would spend the rest of her life with, they pulled away without even a single tear, leaving her to sob and fall apart for weeks, months- and on one occasion- years.

It was especially difficult, having lived her entire life in Thaymor and never leaving while everyone else went out to explore the world even with the dangers the war brought.

And so, it took one to know one.

A person suffering from a broken heart. She saw the familiar way in which the girl crumbled on the inside, leaving her body to follow as she fell to her knees on the dirt and debris left behind by the Horde. She saw the way the girl clawed at the ground, staring at the space in front of her as if she could get back what she lost, as if it hadn't floated away in the wind, leaving her alone and sorry.

She saw the way tears gathered silently, no one in the world truly caring because why bother with something as pitiful as heartbreak when there were more important matters in the world. But Katya knew that at that moment, nothing else mattered to the girl.

It was right then that Katya, along with all the others in the village, began to realize that Horde soldier or not, at the end of the day they were all simply people, and they could all collapse into tears and grief just as this girl before them had.

Maybe none of them could avoid it.

Every night.

Every night, Jack stared out the window of his ruined house for as long as he could. He was lucky, his little hut-like house hadn't sustained as much damage as the rest of the homes. He had to sleep in a makeshift bed, but he still had four semi-sturdy walls surrounding him. He felt safe enough to stay awake for hours.

Sometimes his mom would come and reprimand him for staying up so late, but even to a ten-year-old boy the sight behind him was inexplicably complex and sorrowful.

Not that he would describe it that way at his age.

To him, the sight simply captured his attention in a way that nothing else could.

The moonlight would cast a dramatic look upon an equally dramatic scene. A girl, with wildly unkempt hair and glistening claws. She would sit in a carefully cleared-out spot, and simply stare longingly. Jack didn't know how long she stayed out, sometimes if he woke up early enough he'd be able to catch her still sitting there, awake or not. He didn't know where she went during the day.

She was a mystery to everyone, but it was an unspoken rule that the girl was not to be disturbed. Even Jack understood that. He'd sometimes hear his mom murmur, "Poor girl," when they walked past her little circle of dirt. Other times she'd simply shake her head with pity and sad eyes.

They all gave her time. They had an idea of what was going through her head, but no one knew- actually knew- how paralyzed the girl must have felt. For Jack was the only one to stare. Maybe it was rude. Maybe it was inappropriate to watch such an intimate scene between only one person and herself- her heart, her mind. But he could see how unmoving the girl was. She was stuck. She looked like she didn't have a choice but to stay there forever.

Jack hoped he'd never have to feel that way because the girl made it look torturous and painful.

Maybe it was.

She disappeared.

Sindan was starting to get tired of the girl. Every evening he'd go back to his tiny tent and rest after a long day of hard work and the endless sun beating down on him and all the other people rebuilding the village. It was tiring, and it was slow work.

Walking past a sad little girl at the end of his workday didn't help with morale, it didn't help with anything.

The girl was a part of the Horde and therefore part of the reason Sindan and his friends didn't have homes. She didn't deserve to sit around all night in the same damn spot only to disappear for the whole day.

She was probably trying to escape having to work.

Sindan scoffed as he walked past a familiar circle of dirt only to be surprised. It was empty. Or maybe Sindan was early? He looked up at the lowering sun. Nope. It was the same time as any other day these past few weeks, maybe even a little later.

He gulped in worry.

What if the girl who had been getting so thin you could see her ribs these past few weeks disappeared to make an attack plan on the people?

What if the girl that had darkening bags under her eyes had left to alert the Horde that the village was ready for the taking again?

What if the girl was simply gone?

She couldn’t care for herself in that state- in the state that Sindan had noticed only got worse by the day.

He looked towards the woods.

Maybe she’d come back by morning.

Relief.

It’s what filled the villagers of Thaymor when one day, the nameless girl had returned and had wordlessly begun to aid them in the reparations.

She had simply walked up next to Riso and helped them lift a wall that had their knees trembling with strain.

Riso had learned something interesting that day. They learned that the girl with cat ears and a tail had tan-colored stripes on her arms, and she was surprisingly strong.

They learned that even though a week earlier the girl looked like she had been starving, she was now looking healthy. They caught sight of the claws that currently scraped gently against the wall they had just put up and the fangs revealed when the catgirl gave a smirk of satisfaction at having succeeded in helping. Riso wondered if the girl had gone hunting.

It was impressive, the way she had built her body up back to strength, but Riso couldn't ignore the way her eyes were still very dull. She was still lost, and even though helping had brought her momentary satisfaction, it was gone all too quickly.

Only those that got near her could see it. On the outside, the girl looked perfectly fine but a glance at her face, at her unshining eyes, or at her quirking frown would reveal that she was still broken, at least on the inside.

Riso found themselves being helped more and more often throughout the week until their house was mostly fixed, and the girl moved onto the next house.

No one had expected, or even asked for this, and they knew the girl was still nowhere near happy, not with the way her feet would drag when she got too close to a certain area, and not with the way she still sometimes stared at the woods for a minute too long, as if waiting for someone to walk through the foliage and greet her.

Maybe she wasn’t happy, and maybe she hadn’t shared her name with anyone, not even Riso, but...

Maybe she had found a temporary purpose here.

Surprised.

Marcy was surprised when he had first heard the girl speak. She hadn’t uttered a word to anyone in the months she had stayed in Thaymor, but today was a day full of surprises.

She wanted to build a house- or more accurately- a shop. Everyone knew Marcy was the sort of unofficial mayor of Thaymor, they went to her for any village-affecting decisions they wanted to make. She didn’t know how that information had spread to their local harmless Horde soldier, but it did.

And now she was here, standing in the doorway of Marcy’s newly rebuilt house- the house that the Horde soldier had helped fix- and asking her for permission to gather her own materials to build a shop in the middle of the newly repaired village.

It was a good time, she supposed. Months after the Horde had attacked their little town was finally looking decent, all of the homes were mostly rebuilt, the debris had been cleaned, and there were only a few gaps in the place left from people who didn’t rebuild as they had gone to another place, another town.

They were a quaint little place anyway, and everything was mostly done. There would be no sense in rejecting the girl's request, she would be doing all the work after all, but still, as unofficial mayor, Marcy wanted to make sure it was nothing fishy. The girl was still a Horde soldier after all.

"Come in, please. We can discuss this more if you'd like, and I'll let you know what I think."

Marcy was truly the first person to speak to her, and she might not receive a response. She worried that she might scare the girl away, with the apprehensive way she looked inside the house, and at Marcy as she stepped aside to let her in, but the catgirl walked inside carefully.

Marcy closed the door quickly and led them both to her dining table. She lived alone, and it was a bit lonely being the mayor, the light shining beautifully through her windows not making it any less so, but even this stranger she was weirdly fond of made the space a little more livable.

"So, you said you wanted to open a shop? Could you tell me where exactly, about how big, and what it would be for?"

It was a bombardment of questions, and the overwhelmingness of them showed on the girl's face as she had been directly addressed for the first time in months. Marcy could sense the uneasiness, and backtracked.

“I’m sorry, how about we start over,” she said in a kind and soft voice, “What’s your name if you don’t mind?”

The girl cleared her throat, and Marcy waited in anticipation for the answer, for the new speck of information from the riddle that haunted Thaymor, “Catra. I’m Catra.”

Maybe Marcy smiled a bit at the obviousness of the name.

Maybe Catra smiled back for a moment before frowning at the memory of how she had gotten her name, and who had given it to her.

Maybe Catra would make herself a home here.

Interesting.

Everyone in the village was interested as to what exactly the girl was doing. Marcy’s best friend though, Olive, knew what was going on.

She knew what Catra was doing.

Catra hadn't told Marcy to *not* tell people her name, but Marcy had known it was implied that she wasn't supposed to be telling everyone and their mother either. Of course, being her best friend, Marcy told Olive, and now Olive watched Catra build her little wood carving shop.

She carried logs of wood and made cement mixed back and forth all day. It was by far the most entertaining thing that had happened in Thaymor for a long time.

Olive watched from the sidelines, not hiding the way she saw every little thing Catra did. People offered their help, perhaps in payment for Catra having helped them build back their homes, but she rejected them every time.

Catra had a very determined look in her eyes, a stark contrast to the sadness always hidden in them.

Oh, it was still there, hopeful but also accepting, as if she was looking for someone to come and approve of what she was doing, but she knew they would never come.

No Catra was doing this for herself, Olive could tell. It wouldn't hurt to have some help though.

Catra struggled with the cement mixture she was making, mixing it with a stick of all things. Olive noticed she did everything with her claws, cutting down the trees and turning them into

something she could build with. She made her own tools, never asking anyone if she could borrow theirs, or even if what she was doing was right.

Olive watched her struggle for days. Curse words would fill the night as they all tried to sleep, and the villagers knew it was just Catra failing at making another mixture, but they also knew offering help would be in vain. All they could do was cover the little one's ears and hope Catra would get it soon.

It was one night though, when Olive and Marcy stayed up late chatting, that they heard the most heartbreaking sounds. It was sudden, and it was the moment they all realized Catra still hadn't recovered.

It was when she gave an excited whoop that echoed through the night sky, followed by an excited, and cut-off "I did it! Look Ado-..."

The word faded away and Catra swallowed the rest of the sentence.

And maybe she spent the rest of the night sitting next to her mixture, sobbing in loneliness.

Maybe Marcy and Olive realized that the girl was even lonelier than they were.

Follower

Chapter Summary

> Catra's thought process leading up to the shop, a few mishaps, and when something is exposed Catra's temper is re-ignited.

Chapter Notes

> You guys seem to really like when I write angst haha. I don't think it's as good as my crack writing because I can't cover up my shitty writing with bad jokes and fluff, but here you go! Better late than never.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Matches burn, after the other

Pages turn and stick to each other

Wages earned, and lessons learned

But I

I'm right where you left me

Help

I'm still at the restaurant

Sitting, in a corner, I haunt

Cross-legged in the dim light

Open.

It's what the sign of Catra's new little shop read.

It was a step towards her new life. The shop's sturdiness was a symbol and a sign that she would be staying here. She would be staying here… without Adora.

Nearly every day she contemplated going out and looking for her, asking her to come back to Thaymor with her or even staying wherever Adora was herself. But she couldn't.

She couldn't because Adora was out being that magical princess that had surprised the entirety of the Horde and going out to search for her would either only drag Adora down or completely shatter Catra's heart again if she was rejected.

Besides, that pair of fancy nobles looked to be doing just fine keeping Adora stable. It was for the best. If Adora wanted to come looking for Catra, no one could say that it was her fault for leading Adora to crumble down this sad attempt at a new life in a small town.

Catra needed a new purpose.

She had the Horde's purpose, but that wasn't something she wanted to follow, and as Adora left, Catra's purpose of making her happy left with her. So now, she had this.

A wood carving shop.

She had learned how to carve during some time she was in the woods.

Before that, in her first few days, maybe weeks in Thaymor, simply sitting in the village, Catra wasn't fully aware of what she was doing. She'd imagine her life with Adora if she hadn't left, sometimes she'd imagine what would have happened if she would have gone with Adora instead, other times- the times she fell into a spiral in her mind- she'd nitpick at her entire life, every moment spent with Adora, from the time they met to the moment they'd separated, wondering, crying, sobbing, asking,

Where had she gone wrong?

Emotionally drained and not entirely there, Catra disappeared during the day because deep down, no matter how upset she was, how confused she was, she didn't want people to see her in such a weak, vulnerable state. She didn't want people asking her things, or pitying her, or… or worrying about her.

She could do just fine on her own if she wanted to. After a week in the woods, she decided she didn't want to.

It was during that week that she had realized just how frail she was getting. She wondered if Adora would have let her get to this point. Catra conjured up her own distorted moments, where Adora would berate her for not eating, poke at her until she finally got up and did something, and scold her for not keeping up with training, although that one usually ended up sounding more like Shadow Weaver, and Catra would have to cut her happy- false-moments short.

She'd get angry.

Angry, because how could Adora leave her in the first place? Had she been the one to leave Adora? Who had left who? Why couldn't things just be simple, and easy, and *happy* again? How did *Shadow Weaver* end up being right, of all people?

Just the thought of proving the witch wrong was enough to motivate Catra to pull herself together, if only long enough to survive and be… happy? No, that couldn't happen without Adora. Fine, would be a better word. Catra could do fine. Catra could be fine. She just had to figure out how she would do that.

First, build herself up again. Get strong so she could kick anybody's ass and maybe if Adora came back she wouldn't see how low Catra had gotten.

She did it fast, and she did it efficiently.

The wild beasts and bugs in the woods proved to be quite easy to kill, Catra’s natural instincts finally being put to their intended use. The nutrients they provided were far better than whatever the hell was in the rations of the Fright Zone, and Catra was in decent shape by the end of the week.

So she went back to the town she had paid little attention to before. Belly full and muscles built up after running through the trees and leaping with the vines in a way that reminded her of how she and Adora would play between the cables and wires hanging from the Fright Zone's unstable halls.

It sucked, the way that everything she did reminded her of Adora, but she held onto that. She held onto the memories because it was all she could have and she still desperately wanted Adora in her life, one way or another.

She could have Adora in that way, and she could have her new life. Yeah, she could have both. (Even if she knew it was pitiful compared to the real thing)

She didn’t know where to start, honestly. People were building their homes, that much Catra knew from the details she had caught here and there when she was drifting in and out of the present a week earlier, but what could Catra do?

What did people do when they weren’t sleeping or eating? All she had ever known was training and breaks with Adora, but it was a

strict regiment. While Catra might not have followed it to the dot as Adora had, she didn't have much else to do other than what she was ordered to do.

So much free time was… daunting, to say the least. What she eventually decided was she would do what everyone else did. She would build.

How to start? She also didn't know, but you couldn't go wrong with just helping, right? She wouldn't know. People rarely helped each other in the Horde, the only person who had ever *tried* helping her was Adora, and even then Catra never accepted the help. She'd have to guess every step of the way. Walking up to a random person and helping them lift a wall seemed to be a good enough decision. She was able to test out her strength again and people looked happy when she did that.

Step 1, complete.

She had learned about shops after the rebuilding. It was such an experience for her, seeing people open stands and stores as the priority of homes was put aside. Fascinated, Catra had gone into one of the stores, and even though she didn't have any 'money' as the kind lady had put it, Catra walked out with a new set of clothes and a soft smile on her face.

That was something Catra wanted to do. Have a store. It not only provided a distraction, but it could be something useful. She didn't have much to do now that the village was restored, so she set out into the woods again to make her plan. Not disappearing for the

whole week again, but leaving for most of the day, only coming back at night when she knew everyone was back in their homes. She wasn’t quite ready to interact with the villagers yet.

At first, she was going to open a clothes shop, just like the one she had walked into, but she didn’t know where she would get the clothes, and she didn’t know where to buy any or how to make some, so that was dismissed quickly.

She had gone from one idea to another, feeling like Adora with how many plans she carved into the trunks of trees-

Until finally, a glance at her claws slicing through the wood gave her a solid idea.

She learned she could make some decent stuff with her claws after a few days. She'd carve little spoons at first. Then as she got better she started carving patterns into them. After that, she started making little figures of animals and people-

but she stopped one day. It was so sudden, and she’d had several days just like it before, for weeks while she perfected the craft, but today was different.

It was different for the sole reason that subconsciously, she had managed to carve something resembling Adora. The little person had a hair poof and ponytail. A jacket with sharp shoulders and a

belt hung from the figure’s waist. It wasn't the most accurate figurine, but it was Adora nonetheless.

That day, she stayed longer than usual. She stayed until nightfall and then when the sun rose the next morning. She perfected her carving skills.

She carved Adora.

Again and again and again to the point where she thought she was going insane until the image was flawless. It was Adora. With her slightly crooked nose and a cocky little smirk. She had memorized every detail of the blonde's face, and she didn't want to forget.

When she finally realized just how much she was still clinging to her best friend, to her potential more, Catra cried and hugged the carving to her chest as she accepted that the person she loved most in the world wasn't coming back, and she wasn't going to be able to go look for her either.

She came to terms with it, lashed out in anger at a few of the wild beasts who thought they could best her in a fight, and she went back to Thaymor, again.

This time, even if she was a little disoriented still, she went to investigate.

She inspected and analyzed the way the villagers interacted with one another, for she would have to do the same when she finally made the shop and people came in. She would have to learn.

She saw the way they hugged, and laughed, and cheered, and she wondered if maybe what she and Adora had wasn't so special after all. These people all seemed happy in a way that she had only ever been with Adora. But something was missing. These interactions, casual touches, and lack of fear even with a war surrounding them didn't quite have the same tension she and Adora had, especially in more recent years.

She and Adora had always been waiting for the other to do something, to say something. They kept their thoughts hidden though, for fear that Shadow Weaver would discover whatever it was they were thinking about doing. At least, that's what Catra did. She wasn't too sure what exactly had gone on in Adora's poof of a head.

Catra wondered briefly what would have happened had she said and done what she wanted.

Shaking her head, scolding herself for getting so distracted, Catra caught sight of something interesting. From the bushes, she could see people gathering around one of the ladies of the village. The woman with light brown hair and tan skin raised her hand, and she asked a question, 'All in favor,' Catra's enhanced hearing caught.

Catra tilted her head in confusion, nobody else had done anything like it, but it seemed similar to the voting she and her squad would do for who would be sent to work in the sewers that day. It was always, unfailingly Kyle, but Catra understood that it was a group decision and that the leader was the one to ask who voted for what.

Adora would always ask, and Adora was always considered the squad leader. She asked who voted for Kyle to be sent, and who voted for him not to be sent.

The question gave the illusion that there was even a fraction of a chance that Kyle wouldn't go to the sewers.

Maybe this woman was the leader of the village and Catra simply hadn't realized it? Maybe this voting thing was more complex than what had gone on in her squad because the way that some people rose their hands while others didn't, made it clear that these people were actually picking something. They were *choosing* .

She would have to pay more attention to what these people were choosing for and against in future investigations.

She watched and inspected until she finally came to the most logical conclusion; this woman was the one in charge here. The other villagers were free to do as they pleased, yes, but when they planned on doing something big, something important that others might not want, they went and asked the lady for permission. Sometimes the lady would immediately give her yes

or no answer, sometimes it took more discussion, and people would walk into her newly rebuilt house. Other times, she would ask all the other villagers what they thought, they would *vote* .

Catra figured that was something she would have to do if she wanted to make her short-term dream come true. Sighing, Catra readied herself and planned out what she would say to the lady.

"'Hi, my name is Catra, I want to build a store-' no, too forward. 'Hi, I'm Catra. You've probably seen me around-' ugh no! I can't just, *assume.*

Catra was so used to only speaking to Adora, and growling at anyone else, that she couldn't even figure out how to talk to someone. It was embarrassing.

She set up a ranking system though. This lady seemed to be in charge, but she seemed nice. She could talk to her like she would the Sergeants of the Horde. Formally, trying not to get in trouble, but also not like she would talk to Shadow Weaver when she didn't want to get punished. So, not quite stiffly, but… not too casually either. She couldn't be demanding. She held no power here and being mean and cold like she was in the Horde usually kept people away from her. That was the whole point then, sure, but now she had to get on this lady's good side. She could be useful in the future especially since Catra planned on staying. Getting kicked out wouldn't be the end of her world- that had already happened a few months ago- but it wouldn't do her any good either.

Mumbling to herself the whole day, Catra paced around the forest floor and finally got her speech right.

"Hi, I wanted to know if I could build a store like the other ones I've seen. With your permission, of course, and I'll get the materials all myself."

It was a little too nice for Catra's liking, but she would do it if she had to.

A day later, the niceness was proved worth it.

When she finally started the construction of her shop, she had some setbacks, and sometimes when she finished something she looked around, half expecting Adora to tease her about being so proud, and sometimes realizing Adora wasn't actually there made Catra stop for days at a time as she fell back into her storm of upset emotions.

But she did it. She had built the shop, made tables, shelves, counters, and stuff to give away or sell. She made sure none of her more impromptu stuff would fall apart the moment something shook it too hard, and most importantly, she had carved a subtle circle into the floor.

She had marked that circle when she first started building months ago. It was the spot she stood at when she walked away from Adora and Adora walked away from her.

Some people might think it weird, that she framed the spot in which she had made the decision she regrets most in life, but Catra wanted it there.

As a reminder.

A reminder of what? She wasn't too sure, but she wasn't getting rid of it either.

Maybe she’d never be able to.

Telling people.

Martha had told her sister.

You couldn’t blame her, of course. The new little wood carving store in Thaymor simply sold the most adorable pieces of carved animals she had ever seen. It was something to brag about for once.

Her small village life was eternally boring compared to her sister’s big city life in Brightmoon’s neighboring towns, and she finally had something good to tell Alty when she called to berate Martha for

staying in Thaymor. It was the third time this month, the hundredth time this year, and she was tired of it.

She knew the store owner, Catra, (everybody in Thaymor knew now) was a relatively private person, and it was probably best to keep attention away from the place she lived when the Horde was still out and about, even if it *was* losing the war right now.

But she couldn't help it. She bragged about the store to Alty and she knew her sister simply wouldn't be able to resist coming to see for herself.

Alty came, and she ordered an entire dining set. She stayed at Martha's for the week while Catra completed the order, and Martha could simply tell she was miffed when the set came out to be the best furniture Alty had ever seen.

Alty left with a huff and she never brought it up again, probably going to gloat about her new table and four chairs to her friends without telling them that Martha was the one who had recommended the store in the first place.

Martha was happy, overly so, but it saddened her every time she walked into the store. Catra wasn't exactly happy. She wasn't letting herself be. She was making friends and acquaintances with her new business, and she received compliments from everyone. But she kept them all at arm's length.

Maybe Catra was holding back.

Maybe Catra was still holding onto something herself.

Rejected.

Tania wasn’t even sure why she had done it.

Maybe it was just the popularity that Catra was gaining with her little store.

Maybe it was the mystery that Catra presented even if everyone talked to her now.

Maybe she just thought Catra was hot compared to everyone else in the village.

Tania did something stupid.

After only a few days of knowing and talking to Catra like everyone else, Tania decided to try and ask Catra out.

No, she *did* ask Catra out.

Catra’s reaction wasn’t what she had expected. Sure, Tania hadn’t expected a yes, not really. But she also didn’t expect Catra’s ears to pin back so quickly. She didn’t expect Catra’s breathing to intensify to the point where she was almost hyperventilating. She didn’t expect Catra’s eyes to well up with tears after so long of people not having seen her cry. She didn’t expect Catra’s hands to start trembling. She didn’t expect Catra to stumble her way to the back of the store.

Tania didn’t expect a lot of things.

Even Catra herself had not expected that to happen, but the realization that she would never find anyone who brought her the same happiness Adora had, broke her.

Catra feared she would never be happy again.

Catra feared forgetting about Adora and loving someone else in such a fake way that it became her new normal.

Maybe she’d never dare to try.

So Busy.

Drint worried about his friend.

He never thought he’d say that about a Horde soldier- an *ex*-Horde soldier, but it was true.

He saw Catra at the shop almost every day, whether it was to buy something or simply chat with her while she worked. It was a thing of beauty, watching her carefully drag and dig her claws through carefully picked wood or seeing the way she used her muscles to saw through the larger piece of wood because 'I don't want to damage my claws, Drint. They're like gold to me and everyone else here'. She looked so intense when she did it, and she made sure there was full effort into the piece. She didn’t slack off and she made sure the result was exactly as it needed to be.

She made sure she was the best at what she did and she didn’t even know it. Drint didn’t know why Catra seemed so determined to do so with every piece. Her more minimal carving could sell for the same price she sold her fully finished products here in Thaymor where people would take any little thing they could get. He didn’t understand her, but he respected her nonetheless.

That’s why it made him so upset to see the look in her eyes when she wasn’t actively carving something.

They were almost hollow, worsening, and she’d simply sit and stare all day if she had nothing to do. Getting her to talk was already something Drint and any other person had to work at, getting her to talk about herself, or her previous life was next to

impossible. He figured Tania's idiocy would only make it harder from now on.

He realized she kept herself so busy- so in motion, that she never had time to think about anything other than carving, carving, carving.

She didn't even do much with the money she received. She hunted for her food and clothing was one of the first new things she had bought. An outfit or two and nothing more.

The carving was Catra's life, her purpose now, but she was lonely and it didn't make her happy for much longer than hours at a time.

Looking in the direction that Catra was currently staring in, Drint realized maybe he could find what had made her happy before.

Rumors.

They were spreading, and fast. About why their soft and secretly emotional woodcarver was so angry. Everyone looked at each other with suspicious gazes. Catra being upset, sad, crying, was normal. As unfortunate as the case may be, it was common for people to catch Catra wiping a stray tear away from her eyes.

She probably thought she was great at hiding it, but she really wasn't.

It was normal to see Catra carving quietly in a dark corner of the store instead of in the back. She seemed to like the solace that came with the corner, purposefully left unlit.

It was normal to see Catra swiping her claws against the walls of her store in frustration. The deep furrows and gauges left behind were almost decorative at this point.

What *wasn't* normal, was seeing Catra outwardly growling and hissing unintentionally at people, grumbling distractedly and deep in thought.

She wasn't mad at them, the villagers. No, the way in which she always had a sorry look on her face after someone left her in favor of talking with someone in a better mood told them that Catra was mad at something else.

Someone had said something.

At first, the villagers had gone to interrogate Drint. It was known that he was one of the closest to Catra, but he confessed that he knew nothing. He didn't think anything he said would have upset Catra so much. After much more questioning (that Catra was unaware of) towards Drint and his conversations with Catra, it was determined that he wasn't the culprit.

The questioning only intensified when Marcy as the mayor had gone to discreetly question Catra and accidentally found a chart of plans hidden in a drawer.

The plans were dangerous, to Marcy and the villagers this was no longer their stray Horde soldier being heartbroken or angry.

This was a dangerous person who believed she was better off alone but was still willing to put herself in harm's way-

maybe even willing to give it all up just for them if plan A didn’t work.

Chapter End Notes

What do you think Catra's planning? What was exposed? (this is not for dramatics please give me some better ideas than what I have).

Adora's POV in the next one, and we see why she never went back.

Plan for Revenge

Chapter Summary

We get the POVs of Adora, Glimmer, Angella, Bow, and Shadow Weaver

Chapter Notes

haha

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She was gone.

Adora thought Catra was gone. Dead.

After months of being distracted in battle, hoping to catch a glimpse of a familiar red mask or even claws attacking her stealthily, Adora lost hope.

At first, she was in shock. She had left the Horde. She had left *Catra* .

But… Catra didn't want to come with her. Maybe she would in time.

Maybe she could convince her if she was just *better* the next time they saw each other.

Eventually, the maybe never came. Every time the rebellion encountered the Horde, Adora would look everywhere, interact with everyone and check all the soldier's helmets to see who was inside. It was never Catra and each time, Adora's heart would drop a little more.

A pit grew in Adora's stomach, and she became obsessed with finding Catra. She set up a board connecting any little clue that might lead to where the hell Catra was, because it had been months and she wasn't in any battles. She should have already graduated and been sent out to the field with the rest of the squad but she wasn't *anywhere* .

At one point, she considered charging into the heart of the Fright Zone and just looking for Catra there. Demanding that either Shadow Weaver or Hordak tell her where she was because *someone* had to know.

She knew that was a stupid plan though, and it could endanger Catra.

Glimmer and Bow thought she was crazy. Whenever they ventured out into the whispering woods for a diplomatic mission, Adora would look at every. single. tree.

It had started once she caught sight of claw marks littering a single section of the woods. Adora had been about to brush her suspicion off as a wild animal just scratching up the trees, but

something told her that wasn't the case. Desperately, Adora stopped Glimmer and Bow in their tracks, making them wait for her to finish *measuring* the marks until Adora came to a completely solid but hypothetical conclusion: Catra had been here.

By how deep the marks went and how long they were, Adora explained to them that Catra was likely making them in a fit of some sort of anger.

Neither Glimmer nor Bow believed her, and they wouldn't let her take the tree. They wouldn't let her keep looking. They were concerned.

So, Adora started to hide her thoughts on Catra. Meaning she hid nearly all her thoughts that weren't related to the war. (except Catra *was* related to the war, because she wasn't in it. Not anymore)

She hid her mild obsession with finding her best friend, and she hid her worries.

Adora, for how many conclusions she came to, couldn't admit, couldn't say aloud the one that made the most sense. To everyone.

She couldn't say it out loud and so, someone else said it for her. In Mystacor.

She was fighting Shadow Weaver, when the witch revealed it.

"That nuisance is dead, Adora. Gone and it's *your* fault. Maybe if you had been more responsible like I warned you, she could have lived," she spat out in frustration after trying so, so many tactics. Shadow Weaver was done playing nice, frustrated that even her promise of Adora ruling the world hadn't convinced her. "She failed her mission in Thaymor. You were gone. Failures, are not tolerated in the Horde, Adora. You know what happens to those that have no use. I would have done it long ago if it weren't for your disgusting attachment to her, but once you were no longer an obstacle, both Horak and I were able to dispose of her," she cackled, watching Adora's face wall and seeing her protege's heart shatter.

Adora looked down at the sword in horror.

Had she traded this- this sickening, controlling weapon for… for Catra's life?

Nausea overwhelmed her at the thought.

"No, no you're lying, like you always have, just like Catra told me," she didn't want to believe it but going over the last time she had spoken to Catra made it clear,

Shadow Weaver is freaking out! It'd be funny if she weren't such a terrible person.

Duh! Did ya just figure that out? Manipulation is Shadow Weaver's whole thing! She's been messing with our heads since we were kids

Because you left me! And if I don't bring you back, Shadow Weaver's gonna have my head!

Glimmer teleported her away

Adora!

Catra disappeared into the smoke

Catra....

Shadow Weaver's gonna have my head!

Her voice cracked at the realization, "You- you killed her- you-"

A whimper cut her off and a sob shook Adora's body, Shadow Weaver only smiling cruelly as she watched Adora fall apart.

You killed my best friend, you killed… you killed the love of my life

"How could you! She was everything to me and- and-" Adora's vision was blurry with tears, and she felt weaker than she ever had in her life. Not even when Shadow Weaver took her rations and made her run on 3 hours of sleep for a week had she felt like this. Because at least then she had Catra then.

Catra, who would wrap her tail around her wrist in secret comfort. Catra, who would patch her up after sparring because her claws were so sharp. Catra, who shared everything with her because each other was all they had.

Had the last thing they said to each other really been the other's name?

Angry- at Shadow Weaver, at Hordak, at this stupid war, at the stupid sword, at She-Ra- Adora screamed as she struck the woman in front of her and directed the moon's light where it needed to be. As Shadow Weaver was defeated and the lunarium restored, all Adora felt was an emptiness she feared would never go away.

She didn't even care that the people were waking up now and they would hear her scream and cry and pound her fists against

the step she was on.

She didn’t care that someone could get injured when the sword fell and clattered to the ground below her when she pushed it away from her.

She didn’t care that Glimmer and Bow were next to her now, trying to get her to calm down because they didn’t know what she lost, because they’d never seen her anywhere close to the state she was in.

She didn’t care that she felt She-Ra fade away from inside her, the spirit of the warrior knowing it wasn’t welcome in Adora’s body.

She didn’t care because Catra was gone and she didn’t even get to say goodbye.

Changed.

Adora had changed. Glimmer didn't think Adora had been particularly *normal* in the first place, what with her weird need to measure tree marks and set up obscure chart boards, but even then Adora had been relatively neutral in her emotions. Anything else could be brushed off as the Horde's conditioning of its soldiers.

Now though, Adora was… cold, if anything.

The first few weeks after her hysterical breakdown- something nobody- not even Angella- had seen coming- Adora was depressed. That in itself was clear. She wouldn't get up from bed, she wouldn't eat, shower- nothing.

She told Glimmer and Bow it was too hard, that she just *couldn't* once the blonde had started speaking to them again. It almost seemed as if she had been angry at them before that.

Worst of all, as much as Glimmer loved her new friend dearly and cared about her mental and physical health, She-Ra was nowhere to be seen.

Once Adora finally got up and started attending alliance meetings after a few months, it was confessed that she didn't just *not* want to summon She-Ra, she *couldn't.*

It sent the people inside the room in a panic. Angella looked up with worried eyes, more so for Adora than She-Ra herself, because there was something greatly wrong with their adopted Horde soldier if she couldn't summon the magical being that was meant to be a part of her.

Glimmer and Bow worried because what if people didn't want *Adora* around anymore? They had already gotten to know the relatively harmless, dorky ex-Horde soldier, but only a few months

in Brightmoon made it so people really only trusted *She-Ra* . What would happen if they found out Adora didn't have her anymore? Would she be hunted down the same way she had been when she first arrived?

Adora didn't seem to care about anyone else's feelings, though.

For once, Adora watched the chaos unravel inside the war room, she turned away, and quietly walked out, leaving the Sword of Protection on the floor like it was trash.

After that, Adora was still invited to planning sessions for her strategic knowledge, but when she spoke, she no longer held the same passion she did when helping the alliance, or when helping people in general.

It was like she was *willing* to keep helping the rebellion, but she wasn't going to go above and beyond for them.

Not anymore.

And maybe Glimmer *did* worry about that a little too much, She-Ra was supposed to help turn the tide of the war, after all.

But they were still at a stalemate with the Horde.

Either way, if it came down to it Glimmer would choose Adora over She-Ra any day.

Maybe Glimmer chose Adora, but it was too late because Adora had died with Catra and no one knew it.

Grief.

Angella had seen the drastic change in the poor child, and she recognized it far too easily.

Not just grief for the loss of anyone- no this was grief over the death of the person you loved most in the world.

She had felt it when she learned Micah died in a battle she sent him to.

Angella had an idea of who Adora had lost, the girl that she sketched crudely in her notes and charts. Somehow, no matter how lacking Adora was in her drawing skills, she managed to make the girl with sharp fangs and wild hair look beautiful in the most longing way possible.

Catra was always better at drawing , she had heard the girl mutter during a meeting one day.

But that was before.

Now, Catra, it seemed, had disappeared from Adora’s life, and soon the small doodles in her notes followed, the margins and corners left as blank and empty as Adora’s heart must have been.

But no matter how dark and endless Adora’s stare seemed to be when she was caught zoning out during the day and staring into the void, she held a special glare for the Sword of Protection.

She no longer wanted it. She hated the sword with her entire being and Angella, for the immortal life of her, couldn’t figure out why.

Maybe it was because Adora was letting herself fall apart in isolation. Just as Angella had let the first Princess Alliance fall apart after Micah died.

But it was different, because while Adora was falling apart, she still had a passion in her. A fiery and dangerous anger held against She-Ra herself, and while the legendary warrior was of much use, Adora was terrifying on her own.

Angella and Juliet, they both went over Adora's old records of the Horde, and developed their own.

An exemplary cadet.

Trained with a staff weapon since age six and high physical prowess.

Adora could take down half of the Brightmoon Royal guards if she really wanted to, Angella had seen her train in the mats room one day.

The girl, for how young she was, was incredibly skilled. She lacked experience, but she was gaining it by the day.

Gone was the funny, clumsy at times, and a bit oblivious teenager that smiled with bright blue eyes.

All that was left was the formal and disciplined Force Captain that could accept and give orders with ease.

Angella didn't want to know what she would do if something set her off. It wasn't likely, she had already lost what she cared most for, but whether she was lost or *taken* was another matter.

Who knew?

Maybe Adora was planning something, given how much time she spent holed up in her room.

Happy.

Bow was happy and not worried for the first time in a while.

Adora had very, very eagerly accepted when he and Glimmer asked her to go to Thaymor with them.

After a visit to his dad's to try and figure out what was up with Adora's connection to She-Ra, Bow had spotted a collection of carved figurines on a new shelf in the library. Finding them all adorable, Bow asked Lance and his dad responded with equal enthusiasm that it was all from a little shop in Thaymor.

Squealing with excitement the whole way to Brightmoon, he begged Glimmer to go with him, and she suggested they try and take Adora with them.

Their new friend hadn't left the castle in weeks, refusing to go out for anything other than a mission. She was always so busy, and no one knew what she was doing. Bow was a little hurt, but if it made Adora more comfortable, he would leave her be. He had been scared when he woke up from Shadow Weaver's attack only to hear screaming. Nothing could get Adora to calm down until she fell into a sort of shock state.

Purging the thought from his mind, Bow looked over his shoulder to look at Adora again. Focus on the positive. Adora's eyes had sparkled like she'd seen a horse when Bow cautiously suggested they go to Thaymor for a little shopping trip.

It was almost as if Bow had offered her exactly what she wanted, what she needed, and Adora nodded her head, clearing her throat to snap a quick yes that had Glimmer and Bow both shocked but unquestioning. They'd take whatever they could get at this point.

Maybe she'd even find something that made her happy again.

Duped.

Shadow Weaver, over the course of months, had effectively duped Hordak. Not much of a brag considering the clone stayed in his damned lab all day, but it was a success nonetheless.

She had been ever so slowly convincing him for another attack on Thaymor. At first, Hordak had insisted that wasting supplies and soldiers on the raid of a meaningless town was useless. But after months of the Horde doing *nothing* , gaining no territory, Shadow Weaver kept targeting it, claiming it was an easy win and it would raise morale for the Horde.

Likely tired of her endless demands, Hordak approved of Shadow Weaver's plans without a second thought as long as she led the entire thing and made sure everything went smoothly.

Of course, Shadow Weaver hid her true intentions. She wanted to raid Thaymore because she couldn't leave any loose ends. If the day ever came that Adora found that treacherous and weak animal again, Shadow Weaver's plans could fall apart should Adora come for her. So, she edged closer to the small town day by day. It would scare the people nearby just enough to keep them from fighting back, but they wouldn't see the attack coming. The number of transports sent out to the woods increased by the day, cutting a clear route through the Whispering Woods for the future tanks. She made the soldiers get accustomed to the treks and environment that was the haunted woods. She hadn't lied in those stories about the Whispering Woods being haunted. The trees and foliage protected itself in any way possible, willing to make people disappear if needed.

She needed the soldiers to survive if they were going to be taking towns within the forest.

If she was lucky, maybe Catra would even come to her.

Resentment.

Adora held resentment for a lot of things.

The princesses, the sword, Shadow Weaver-

And the more she learned during her time with the princesses, without Catra, the more her resentment grew.

She learned that the Princesses hadn't protected any lands beyond their own in years, that the Princesses didn't ever stay to help people after they had been attacked.

She learned that she was being controlled, *again* , by the first ones, by She-Ra, by Light Hope.

She was taught that what Shadow Weaver had done to her and Catra was wrong.

She *realized* that she was the only person around who cared about *everyone* . Because no matter how much time she spent fighting against the Horde and planning against them, everytime she took a soldier down all she could imagine was herself, Lonnie, Kyle, Rogelio, or *her* inside the uniform.

Adora may have been a princess without knowing it all along, but she remembered her life in the Horde. As much the Rebellion claimed to want to help people, they hated the Horde and couldn't care less about innocent civilians. They were too scared to take the necessary steps to end the war because they didn't want to look like the bad guys.

Well, Adora was done. She was done worrying about what other people thought of her. She was done worrying about all these new *rules and laws and steps* . She had been raised to fight and all she and the others did in this stupid castle was sit around. Planning and planning but never actually doing anything because Angella was too scared to send her kid into battle while there were thousands of other kids being trained to go out and kill for something they didn't believe in. Automatically labeled as the bad guys.

Adora may not have She-Ra, but she still had her knowledge, and she tracked the Horde's every move, day by day, until she realized they were moving to attack Thaymor *again* . Months after the first attack where she had naively turned the place to rubble with her brutish fighting and left the villagers to deal with the problem, happy to keep on moving and forgetting about it. *No one had helped them* .

They built themselves back up and the Horde was moving in to take them down again. Adora knew what it was like to lose everything, and she wasn't going to let it happen again.

She inspected movements again for weeks on end until she finally realized why the strategy looked so familiar. Shadow Weaver had taught her this plan herself, and she was leading the assault on a town that had no value to the Horde.

But why?

Maybe if she went there, Adora would find out.

Maybe She-Ra could finally be put to good use.

Chapter End Notes

The explanation for some OOC: in this AU, the Horde never advances as much as Catra made it expand, and since Adora has rejected She-Ra for the moment, Angella never deems it safe enough for Glimmer to continue her diplomatic missions, so they're just stuck in a stalemate and Shadow Weaver has the space to do whatever she wants. She's given up on getting Adora back for the moment. Adora, left to her own devices, is in a more physical way quite literally doing nothing, and she's lost all hope. So yeah, she's mad at the Rebellion and at She-Ra because she just has so much time to analyze and really see how the war is going, especially when it's going at such a slow rate.

I wasn't going to post this so early, but I finished it and when I went to write the next chapter, I realized I couldn't without knowing what you guys thought. The next chapter is probably going to take longer to post as well, so this is sort of a 'sorry' for that :)

So Close.

Chapter Summary

Will Catra and Adora finally reunite?

Chapter Notes

Here's your update! The violence does get a little more graphic in this one, not too much I would say, but still like- blood and breaking bones and suffocating, sorta. If you didn't notice, Adora's POV didn't get Taylor Swift lyrics because she's sad, but not Taylor Swift Sad™

See the end of the chapter for more notes

'Cause I'm right where

I cause no harm, mind my business

If our love died young, I can't bear witness

And it's been so long

But if you ever think you got it wrong

I'm right where

you left me

Angry.

Catra was angry. Because it was through gossip that Catra had learned that the Horde was inching closer. *Stupid,* she mentally scolded herself. She should have been paying more attention to the Horde instead of wallowing around and pretending everything was fine. Even if she wasn't a part of the Horde anymore, Hordak and Shadow Weaver were still out there, trying to conquer Etheria for a really stupid reason, probably.

She spent weeks setting up a plan because of that. Entire holes dug and filled with sharpened scrap wood stakes and hidden with the forests' foliage were set up surrounding the whole town. Ready to terminate whatever poor horde unit fell on their march towards the villagers.

The Horde had tanks, and canons though, and nothing Catra could do with the wimpy supplies she had would be enough.

So she trained. She looked for any creature in the woods that might want a fight, and she took them down. She sharpened her claws because she knew they could cut through the canons if she really wanted them to. She had to be realistic though. As much as Catra wanted to be enough, enough to stop the Horde, enough to protect these people, she knew she wasn't. She couldn't ask the people to fight either, they weren't meant to be an army and she didn't want them to get hurt either. She would rather die than see someone else get hurt.

The compromise? She was going to ask Marcy if she could train them. Not because she wanted them to fight alongside her, no that was too dangerous, but because it was a precaution. They'd be able to defend themselves *if needed* . While Catra held off the Horde, they could run and if they encountered any Horde soldiers,

they'd hopefully be able to take them out. After that, if she survived, Catra could go to the princesses and she'd beg if she had to. She'd beg for them to be defended because they weren't going to be able to defeat the Horde on their own. Catra would offer anything, she'd let herself become a pawn in someone else's war again if she had to.

Maybe with that excuse, she'd be able to see Adora again and scold her, wherever she was, because she definitely wasn't out here helping them.

Nervous.

When Catra entered her house for the second time in nearly a year she had been at Thaymor, Marcy was nervous. Catra had been angry and when Marcy went snooping through her things, she realized why, and she knew the girl was going to get herself hurt. She knew Catra wasn't going to stop though, and Marcy could only guess why she was here.

"Marcy."

"Catra. How have you been?"

Small talk. Introductions. Formalities. Marcy knew Catra hated them. But she didn't want Catra to know that she knew. If Catra ever found out, who knew how she would react? Catra's privacy was so very important to her, and Marcy had already invaded it.

"I want to train you all, for when the Horde comes. I don't want you guys to fight," *I'm going to fight by myself, so you can all have a chance,* "but you need to know how to defend yourselves, and I have a planned out schedule and lessons," *I don't want you all to wander in the woods and find the traps,* "but if you don't want to do that it's fine, I can find something else," *I'll skip right to plan B and go to the princesses for help.*

Marcy could read in between the lines and it was terrifying. Everytime Catra spoke, there was a reservedness, one that Marcy could never peel away, and so she didn't know much about Catra. It was unsettling now, to know the hidden message behind every single word. When she finally replied, Marcy wondered if Catra could *smell* the fear on her, which- that was probably speciesism of some sort- but Marcy genuinely considered it. "Ah, well, considering this is a decision that will affect everyone, uh, I will have to call a vote for it, but I'm sure if you present the schedule and your reasoning, a lot of people will agree with you," Marcy reassured.

Her hands trembled as she walked out the door though, and Catra noticed it embarrassingly fast, "Hey are you, you know, okay?" The girl was still a bit uncomfortable with blatant care, but Marcy knew she meant well.

"Yes! Of course," curse her small town, boring life. She hadn't had to keep a secret like this since her academy days when Olive told her that Jessica had hooked up with a guy from Salineas, "I just- I'm getting a little more nervous what with the Horde getting closer. Stars know we don't need a repeat of last time!" She chuckled nervously, but regretted her words when she noticed the

furrow in between Catra's brows and the clench of her jaw. Dammit, she was just making Catra more upset and worried. "I'm sure your new suggestion is bound to help us out though, thank you, Catra. You realize you mean very much to us- to me, right?"

A light blush covered Catra's cheek, not as visible because of her fur, but Marcy knew. With a curt nod, Catra turned away, a few tears in her eyes, and she redirected the subject. "So, how does this voting thing work? I've seen you do it before but how do people know?"

Answering her question, Marcy hollered out, loud enough for Thaymor and the next town to hear. Recognizing the sound, people began to file out of their homes, unquestioningly following each other until they reached Marcy and Catra.

Skilled.

Sindan was surprisingly skilled with the wooden staff Catra made for him. Well- she had made the same staff for everyone, but Sindan was known for claiming the one with the weird pattern right at the top of the staff.

He was pretty damn good with the thing as well. Training had only started about two weeks ago, and he was moving quickly through Catra's lessons. That was one thing she did. She had them all going at their own pace. Claiming it was strategic, why hold others back and push those that weren't ready? Sindan, from construction worker to staff fighter, guessed that Catra had been either one at some point. She might have been pushed too early, but the girl was strong and he knew she adapted. Or, she had

been held back, forced to put away her claws and train with the other ‘cadets’ with the staff she was now so skilled with.

That was one thing she did too. She called the kids ‘cadets’ instead of soldiers like she did the adults. Maybe it was so she could have that clear separation of who was *supposed* to be training and those who were doing it because it was too important to not have them train. Sindan betted that Catra wouldn’t be training the kids if she didn’t have to. She was extra gentle with them too. Lowering her voice and kindly correcting them as well.

Not that she was mean with the adults either. Sindan felt pushed to his limits, but never beyond. Catra respected them and they respected her. Which is why he was so terrified when she suggested he spar with her.

Catra wasn’t going to use her deadly claws, but it didn’t make *her* any less deadly. Or skilled, or experienced. From what they had heard- as these training sessions were exposing more than Catra liked about her Horde life- she had been trained with the staff since age six. SIX.

It was disturbing to hear that children were being employed to fight a war, but it really put into frame exactly what Catra could do.

So, with Catra standing in front of him, staff raised and a scary look on her face, Sindan gulped, and got into position as well. He had gone from worrying about the girl and her malnourished state

as he passed her everyday to cowering under her gaze and preparing to ‘spar’.

Sparring my ass. Sindan was about to get knocked flat and he knew it.

It started with a basic move, Sindan brought down the staff with a decent amount of force, and Catra blocked it. Easy.

Catra pushes the staff away with her own and jabs at Sindan, he redirects the staff, and Catra misses. Also easy.

It kept on going like that for a while, easy, repetitive, slow motions that Sindan could block and maybe, just maybe his confidence was growing.

It all deflated when Catra started speeding up, and Sindan had to go faster to keep pace. He was starting to struggle with blocking each blow Catra threw.

Maybe Catra had an unfocused look in her eyes.

Maybe Sindan was actually scared he was going to get hurt because Catra wasn't holding back.

Maybe it took Marcy calling out Catra's name for her to snap out of it, and simultaneously, snap her staff into splinters as it struck a pole that Sindan was standing next to.

Closer.

The Horde was nearing by the day, and Catra knew they would strike soon. She had only gotten to give the villagers about a month of training, nothing compared to the lifetime of it that the Horde soldiers received, but it would have to do.

And as much as she hated it, there wasn't much for Catra to do but sit and wait. Approaching the Horde now was too risky, she'd rather be in home territory and maybe give them a bit of a surprise. Going to the princesses was no use either. From what Catra knew, they wouldn't help, and Catra would just be farther away from Thaymor, unable to protect it.

So she trained the villagers and she trained them hard, until one day, another secret was exposed. She knew Marcy had seemed a bit off, suspicious, but she brushed it off to the pressure of being mayor of a town threatened by the Horde. It wasn't until Marcy couldn't make eye contact with her that Catra started to get really worried.

Not only did it set off Catra's nerves about having done something wrong, it was weird. Like- Adora is horrible at lying and hiding something from you- weird.

But Catra couldn’t bring herself to confront Marcy either. She was scared, because what if she didn’t want Catra in her town anymore, and was too nice to tell her? What did she mess up this time? These people had cared for her in a warm, close way that nobody else in her life had, not even Adora.

Adora’s care was all sparks and ups and downs. This village, this… ‘family’, as she had heard a little boy call it, was gentle and so, so loving that it was unbelievable at times.

Catra believed this was why she had been so hurt when Marcy finally let it slip. Everyone was taking a break from training, and many settled to rest in the biggest shop in the town, Catra carving meaninglessly behind her counter.

“I know what you’re going to do. I’m sorry, I’m so sorry but I can’t keep pretending like I’m fine with your stupid, careless plan, Catra! So you need to come clean right now or so help me young lady,” she had said it in front of everyone, in Catra’s own store. The cat girl hadn’t even seen it coming, as if she didn’t have hidden traps in the woods. Traps that both she and Marcy knew wouldn’t be enough. “You can’t just throw yourself in front of the Horde to buy time when they attack! And we all know they will. You can’t go looking for the princesses if you survive either, Catra. They won’t help. We all know it. We won’t let you.” Marcy stomped her foot, almost like a child. It was a blatant show of determination backed by the rest of the villagers who were standing in the store, now aware of everything Catra was planning to do and ready to stop her- and it made Catra feel loved. But she could never have that for long, could she?

"...You went through my stuff," Catra accused. She didn't sound angry, not quite, "you aren't supposed to go through people's stuff." It was more like, Catra wasn't really sure why she was angry, but she was. Marcy thought it sounded like a child telling someone that their mother had said something was wrong, so now they were telling someone else the same thing. *My moms said you aren't supposed to take other people's food.*

Marcy wondered if Catra had ever said anything like that at a younger age, but she figured not when she saw that it finally clicked for Catra that Marcy did something 'bad'.

"Catra… I just needed to know-"

"No!" Betrayed, Catra's voice cracked and her eyes glazed over, "You aren't supposed to do that! Not anymore!"

Confused, Marcy's head tilted, "Anymore? What are you- what do you mean, Catra?"

"This isn't supposed to happen! You weren't supposed to be like her!" Catra was starting to back away from Marcy- from everyone.

"Like who? Catra, what-"

"Shadow Weaver! Hordak, Lonnie, Octavia- all of them!" Catra's arms waved around, and Marcy had to back away as well.

It hurt. It hurt Marcy that she cared so much for Catra, but she still knew nearly nothing about the girl. None of the villagers recognized the names, but they all knew these were people who had done what Marcy did.

She invaded her privacy. But now Catra understood why what wasn't okay, why that wasn't *normal* . And now she was hurt. She was angry like she had been the weeks before when the gossip around her in the shop alerted her to the fact that the Horde was nearing, and the princesses were nowhere to be seen. "Get out," she growled. Marcy stood shocked. "I said get out! Don't come back!"

With tears in her eyes, Marcy turned and exited the shop, shame surrounding her every being.

"Everyone out… please," Catra spoke before quickly fleeing to the back of the shop, not waiting for anyone to actually leave. After a few moments, deciding whether to trash everything in the store, scream and sob in a corner, or go run again, into the woods, she chose the last option, deciding that her store didn't have to look the way she felt.

So again, she ran. It had been so long since she had run from her problems, from her own emotions, but it was still familiar, almost comfortable. It never stayed that way though, Catra would eventually break- completely this time, she was sure of it.

Searching.

They were nearing Thaymor now, and Adora had already started searching for any signs of the Horde. She still didn't know why Shadow Weaver was coming, but she was and Adora was determined to be ready for anything.

Bow and Glimmer might have started picking up on Adora's weird little precautions, but with how closed off she had been lately, Adora knew they would allow anything right now. Maybe it was a little mean, a little manipulative, but there were more important things going on and Adora wasn't going to let anything stand in the way of helping this town and finally stopping Shadow Weaver.

Finally, the trio made it to a vague town entrance, the path the woods had provided now expanding into a new and Adora might even say improved Thaymor. Adora had seen the town in its full glory for only a few hours before both she and the Horde had left it to crumble and wither away, but it amazed the blonde to see how these people had built the town back up into something just as beautiful as before. At the same time, it only angered her more that the Horde would dare try and take it away again.

It wasn't until the group got closer to the center of the town, and was beginning to be recognized, that Adora was pulled out of her deep thoughts.

Whispers and outraged gasps could be heard throughout, "It's her!"

“Princesses,” people sneered.

“They’re leading the Horde to us!”

“There’s a carving of her in the shop,”

“Wait- that’s the girl! The one who turned the town to dust!”

“She-ra?”

“Yes, this is the legendary She-ra,” Glimmer announced and seemed to showcase Adora.

With the confirmation, the villagers answered rudely, “You shouldn’t be here, you princess types didn’t help after the Horde attack, and now you want to barge in and do what you want? Royalty has no status here you know-”

Glimmer’s ego wasn’t used to hostility and disrespect. “What? We *helped* you all when the Horde came, you can’t just-”

“We can and we will. As the town’s mayor I ask that you leave, please,” Marcy stepped out of her house, having heard the commotion. There were still the remnants of tears lingering in her eyes, but her glare towards Adora was as cold as ever.

Bow was the first to really notice how everyone was looking at Adora. They clearly knew something he didn’t, and Bow wasn’t willing to risk having to report another incident to Angella.

“Thank you, for the… thank you. We’ll be leaving now,” Bow decided for the entire group, seeing as how one of two princesses was unpredictable at the moment, and the other was growing more and more annoyed with the glaring villagers.

As the three turned away, they could hear a single scathing sentence, “That girl has got a lot of nerve showing her face here after what she's done to this whole town-”

“-what she’s done to Catra!” Marcy finished. She huffed, recalling the way Catra had been right after arriving at Thaymor, right after that princess, *She-ra* , had left her. No matter how angry Catra might be with her, Marcy refused to let the person who had hurt her into the town. No. She chased She-ra away so that Catra might be spared more pain when she came back. *If* she came back.

Hurt.

Catra walked back to Thaymor, a little ashamed, but still a little hurt. She held a bit of hope inside. Hope that she could fix things with Marcy, because that woman had been more of a mother to her in a year than Shadow Weaver had in her entire life, and Catra wanted that back.

Catra wanted to tell Marcy how she felt, and she wanted Marcy to explain again. Catra wanted things to be good between them so much, that for once in her life, she let herself hope.

It was the worst idea she had ever had.

Just as Catra was walking through the town, back to the center where Marcy's house was, she heard Marcy's muffled voice, "That girl has got a lot of nerve showing her face here after what she's done-"

That alone was enough for tears to spring back into Catra's eyes and for her to turn back around. Marcy had seen Catra returning, and was done with her, she was sure of it. About to sprint back into the woods and leave, Catra didn't even get to be upset for long. The echo of tanks on uneven ground and the yelps of unaware soldiers falling into traps was enough for Catra's entire attitude to switch.

The Horde was here, and even if Marcy- if the whole village- didn't want her to help, she wasn't going to abandon them either. Her claws dug into the ground as she ran towards the center again, ready to pass the staffs out to the people and have them ready to defend themselves.

Attack.

Adora and Bow argued as they made their way closer to the only village exit and opening. Adora was so close to just leaving them and running back to warn the villagers of the incoming Horde attack, but Glimmer's teleportation abilities threatened to stop her every time.

"No, guys you don't understand!"

"Adora, you didn't tell anyone about this, the Horde isn't coming it doesn't make sense-"

"Bow, it's not just that! It's-"

Faint screams erupted in the distance, "the Horde," Glimmer whispered.

"I told you, they're attacking on the other side of the town," Adora hissed, angry that her friends hadn't trusted her, "come on, we have to help."

The three sprinted back into the town only to find many of the villagers already defending themselves. Even a group of children

was whacking a Horde soldier on the ground.

It shocked Glimmer and Bow, to say the least, but Adora was too busy looking for Shadow Weaver to wonder about why the villagers had any combat experience.

Even without She-ra, Adora could still try and face her, maybe then she'd be able to summon the warrior again. Glimmer was already taking out soldiers and Bow was perched on the roof of a house, shooting at the Horde soldiers from above.

Chaos surrounded Adora, but she overpowered horde soldiers one by one until she was faced with someone vaguely familiar.

"Lonnie?"

"Sup, Adora, looks like I got your position when you and your pet left," she tapped her Force Captain badge and brought her taser down on the blonde, only to be blocked, "Speaking of, where is she?"

Adora paused in her fighting, "What are you talking about?"

"Catra. Where the hell is that-"

Adora’s eyes widened in confusion before narrowing again in suspicion and anger, “Catra’s dead. Shadow Weaver killed her.”

“What?” Lonnie seemed just as confused as Adora now, the both of them backing away from each other in a truce.

“You heard me,” Adora’s confidence in her own words wavered, “Shadow Weaver killed Catra.”

Lonnie scoffed, “She never came back to the Horde, Adora. There’s no way Shadow Weaver could’ve even touched her. I thought she defected with you!”

“No- Lonnie, don’t- don’t do this to me,” Adora’s breath caught in her throat, it couldn’t be true, “don’t say that when you know it’s a lie.”

“Adora,” Lonnie tossed her stun baton aside and forcefully gripped Adora’s shoulders, “I know how much she means to you- how much you mean to each other. Everyone could see it. Even Kyle. I won’t lie to you, not about her. You fucking weirdos are way too codependent and I don’t want you freaking out. She didn’t. Come. Back.”

“But Shadow Weaver said…”

A bolt of red lightning sparked Adora's realization as Lonnie muttered, "Speak of the devil."

But Adora wasn't listening anymore. She turned away from Lonnie and stalked towards the attacks' commander, her breath coming out in short puffs.

Adora didn't even have the sword with her. Pure rage fueled her as she neared the woman who had raised her- done a terrible job of it, but raised her nonetheless.

"What the hell did you do," she yelled, "where is she?!"

"Adora," Shadow Weaver was surprised, but she covered it up smoothly, "come to face me? And without She-ra? You know you're nothing without that magic, not after you left my side."

Shadow Weaver was eerily calm. She obliterated entire houses mindlessly with just a flick of her wrist, no one came to attack her, and someone was taking out her forces far too efficiently. The raid was going to fail, and Shadow Weaver knew it, but she didn't care. She knew something was going to come and stop her, but she had been surprised when Adora showed herself, so clearly it wasn't meant to be her. It was meant to be-

"Catra. Where is Catra? I know you know where she is, so don't try playing-"

“Oh, Adora,” Shadow Weaver tutted patronizingly. Adora would have felt more confident, *looked* more confident if she had the sword with her, the power of a hundred soldiers on her side and ready to be summoned. But she didn’t. All she had was her grit and newfound hope that Catra was still alive. She stepped up to the tank Shadow Weaver commanded from, and stood mere inches from the woman who she knew had more power than her right now.

She was scared, she couldn’t deny it. But she also couldn’t deny that the risk was worth it if it meant getting Catra back.

“She’s here, isn’t she? That’s why you came, you knew there was a risk in letting her be free from the Horde, the risk of her finding me again-”

“Of course there was!” Shadow Weaver was losing her temper. It was almost odd. She rarely ever did that with Adora. No, with Adora it was more subtle, the manipulation, the convincing. The temper was saved for Catra. “Did you think I would leave the wild beast be? No, that creature has been a nuisance since she was born, and I’ll be damned to let her get in the way of my plans, she may not have been doing so before, but she will, eventually. Just like she’s attempting to now.”

Tear them apart.

Catra was zipping past every horde soldier; her main goal was to reach the tanks with cannons mounted on them. They'd do the most damage not only to the people, but to the homes they had *just* rebuilt. Of course, she paused every few steps to slam her elbow into a soldier's head, knocking them unconscious even with the helmet on- now cracked. She slowed in her path if only to dig her claws into the arm of someone holding a stun baton, and forcefully twisting them around to slam into another soldier, her claws slicing through the flesh and bones of the arm the entire time. Another time, Catra had to stop altogether after the soldiers realized who it was that was attacking them. They ambushed her in a group of six, but she took all of them on. She might not have actually trained properly in a good while, but Catra was still the quickest, most agile cadet in her class. Not even Adora could beat her in that.

She slipped through the open spots the soldiers left, hitting them in their weak points and digging her foot claws into their armor. Soon enough, Catra had twisted and flipped out of range, and when they aimed their stun batons at her, she didn't give them enough time to charge up and shoot before she was face to face with the soldiers, almost able to see through the tinted helmets and catch the fearful expressions they all held when she bared her teeth and clawed through them.

Okay, so maybe she wasn't 'zipping' past the soldiers, but she still kept on route until she made it to one of the tanks already blowing things up. She leaped up to the hull, the cannon so close to her head that her ears rang and she could feel the rumble every time a shot was fired. Ignoring the discomfort, Catra forced the hatch open, and she dropped inside, taking only a few seconds to knock out the unsuspecting gunner and driver.

She had wanted to disable more of the tanks just by inputting the retreat code into this one, but the Horde's passwords and data changed monthly and Catra had been gone for just over a year. Things wouldn't work the way she wanted them to, but when did they ever? She'd have to go into the commander's tank and sound the retreating alarm.

Who was commanding though?

Stop it

"Stop it!" Adora had felt helpless a lot lately. It was part of the reason she investigated this raid so closely. Right now, with Shadow Weaver hurting a group of kids- hurting them like she had Catra- Adora felt herself pulled back into her 8 year old self's body.

She was small, weak, slow. She knew it no matter how much Shadow Weaver praised otherwise during training. She knew it because when she didn't do good, Shadow Weaver exposed every flaw. She was stuck, choosing between letting her best friend be paralyzed and shocked and burned because *what could she do anyway?* , or trying and failing at standing up to Shadow Weaver.

She kept hitting Shadow Weaver with her staff, but she was protected by some magic barrier. She didn't know when the sorceress had grown so powerful. "Stop it! Stop it," she screeched, but it wasn't working, it never worked. Not then, not now.

Adora was done letting people be hurt by Shadow Weaver though. Her biggest regret was letting Catra go through it, and Adora wasn't a kid anymore. She backed away from Shadow Weaver, her staff collapsed. It was only going to be her, against the magic, but Adora was going to try anyway. Even if she stopped the assault on the town today, even if she stopped Shadow Weaver from torturing those kids, she'd only continue. It would be never ending.

She's here.

When Catra caught sight of Adora, she couldn't believe it. Seeing Shadow Weaver next to her though, was a little more believable.

For just a moment, Catra let everything else fade into the background. The fighting going on around her was meaningless, and for the first time in a year, Catra felt like she could breathe properly. Adora was here, in Thaymor for whatever reason. It was only when she heard Adora's screams that her thoughts went back into focus, and the roar of battle re-entered her ears.

Adora had a slight glow to her, a golden aura disrupted by Shadow Weaver's contrasting pitch black magic as she appeared to be trying to shove and push past it, pressing her shoulder closer to the witch's torso. Both barriers of magic were glitching, the eerie buzzing sound growing louder by the second, and Catra knew that Adora didn't care. The idiot didn't care that she was going to get hurt because she wasn't that weird princess-warrior she had been when she left Catra.

So being the smart one, Catra started running. She ran to Adora even though she had promised herself she wouldn't.

It was then that she caught sight of the Thaymor kids that Shadow Weaver had taken control over, and Catra's speed doubled. She was *not* going to let them continue getting hurt the same way she was nearly her entire life. Right in between glitches, Catra leaped and tackled the trio of kids, ridding them of the hold the magic kept them in.

She noticed one of them had passed out, likely from the pain. Oh, she was pissed now. These were the kids that brought life to Thaymor. They ran around in circles, kicking up dirt and laughing all day. They were the kids she babysat the one time Harold and Jenna went on vacation to Plumeria. They were the kids that made Catra smile absentmindedly as she remembered the few good times she had with Adora as kids in the Horde. They were a reminder that the Horde hadn't gotten to them, to this town.

She carried them all to more relative safety, instructing the few villagers that she had passed on the way to the edge of the woods to 'Start retreating! Get to safety, I'll finish this here!"

"No!" It was Marcy. "We're not leaving you here Catra- I'm sorry, for everything that happened, everything I did. I still care about you though, and I won't let you do this alone!"

There was no time to argue, and a part of Catra didn't want to.With tears in her eyes, she nodded, deciding to let the villagers defend their home if they wanted to. "I'm not alone though Marcy," Catra turned to look at Adora with a worried expression, "I have her."

Marcy made a face- a grimace, if you will- and Catra laughed. "Her?"

"Yes, *her* ! I have to help her, distract the few soldiers left and get the kids to safety, I should be able to stop the tanks soon, okay?"

Determined, Marcy nodded her assent, "I won't let you down, Catra."

"You could never let me down Marcy."

It was then that Catra realized just how tired Marcy's expression seemed. In her late 40s, Marcy must have been mayor for a long time. Taking charge of something, no matter how big or small, and in the middle of a war that wouldn't leave them be, must have been tiring. Catra would finish this. If not because of Shadow Weaver and her evil, then for Marcy.

Catra turned and ran back to Adora, who was now the one in Shadow Weaver's hold after helping rid the kids of her torture. Shadow Weaver whispered something in Adora's ear, something

that made the blonde’s eyes widen in fear and search for something before she was flung carelessly into a nearby rock.

Catra could hear the crack Adora’s body made from the impact.

Adora wasn’t getting up.

"-ora?! Adora!"

Distantly, she felt her body being moved, a bit gently, but there was desperation in the hold, in the way the hands both clung to her and mindlessly patted away in search of something.

Her hearing was fuzzy and there was a ringing in her head. She didn't think she'd be able to open her eyes even if she wanted to. Her left side felt numb.

"No, wake up, wake up, wake up," there were tears landing on her cheek. "I *just* got you back," her hands were tingling.

"Please don't leave me again, *please* ," she felt the hands close tightly around her jacket, and the person's head leaned into her chest.

"Please, stay…"

No.

Catra felt Shadow Weaver approach from behind, standing over the both of them as Catra cried onto Adora. There was still a pulse, but it was weak, and she didn't know who'd be able to help her in this state.

"Pathetic. And a waste if you ask me."

"No one asked you," Catra slowly turned and rose from her position to face Shadow Weaver. She snarled, "no one cares about you, no one *needs* you, or your opinion! You're just an evil bitch who needs to *die already* . So shut up!”

Catra pounced and clawed at the woman’s mask. Shadow Weaver was strong right now, and Catra wasn’t sure why but she wasn’t going to let that stop her. She was quick, but Shadow Weave had predicted the move.

The soldier in Catra knew she was distracted, not thinking straight. The thought that Adora might not get help in time plagued her mind alongside the lifetime of anger she held in solely for Shadow Weaver. She was swiping her claws foolishly and it cost her. There wasn’t even anyone to help. The Horde raid had retreated without their commander’s orders after seeing how the

villagers had fought back together, and the villagers had run to safety as upon Catra’s request.

Good. It was good now that Catra was held in the air, dark magic trapping her as it circled her body and limbs. Adora still hadn’t woken up, and maybe she wouldn’t anymore. It brought Catra little peace. She was breaking her promise to Marcy if she didn’t take down Shadow Weaver, but that seemed impossible right now.

The magic was tightening around her, cutting off her circulation and rising to her neckline. It made Shadow Weaver’s blood red mask fuzz around the edges as Catra’s vision blurred. The swirling pressure increased as it reached past her neck, pinching around her eyes and mouth. Her head felt like it was going to burst, and Catra had one last thought before she succumbed to the pain and everything went black:

Stars, she hated breaking promises.

Chapter End Notes

The end.

Just kidding! hehe. I know, I know this took a while, but I did warn you all. Most of the reasoning is that I thought I finessed the plot of this story by just asking you guys, but you all had so many different ideas and I loved them all, so it took me a while to try and fit as many as possible in here and in the next chapters. If your idea wasn't exactly what you wanted, or it's just not there, I promise, I'm sorry, I tried so hard to incorporate a little of everything, but it still had to make minimal sense in the end. I hope this was good

enough. There's still more to come, but I figured I made you all wait long enough and this was a fun place to stop. For me. It was fun for me. Not sure when the next update is going to be, there's just so much I want to do and never enough time. Promise it'll be as soon as possible though! Sorry for the cliffhanger I guess...

What now?

Chapter Summary

The chaos has subsided, only for another fight to break out. Bow opts out for once.

Chapter Notes

Another month! I am so, so sorry. This chapter isn't even that long or good. And that last cliffhanger...
to be fair nothing will ever be as bad as Rick Riordian's cliffhanger in MoA...?

PS. no, I don't hate Glimmer and Bow here, there is no slander for them, it's just... monarchy... you know?

** Shadow Weaver's death does get a tad bit graphic, and Catra's pain is sort of heavily described, so if you need to skip that it starts at the start of the chapter and ends a little after the subtitle "What?" at the line "Finally, Catra was able to slowly open her eyes,"**

Hardly any revisions this chapter

See the end of the chapter for more notes

I'm going to rid myself and the world of that beast once and for all, Adora. And it will be your *fault.*

Adora panicked in the moment. Shadow Weaver would do it, she knew she would, that's why Adora fell for it the first time. But the bare honesty accompanying the sorceress's words sent a chill down Adora's spine and a shot of panic through her being. For the first time in months, Adora really wished she still had her sword.

She also really hoped Bow and Glimmer were still around. She had lost sight of them in all the commotion, but if they would help Catra, then that was all Adora needed from them. At least Bow would be willing to help if Glimmer somehow realized she was ex-Horde. If they had just *listened* to her. Maybe Adora wouldn't be stuck in her own head and unable to move.

She felt paralyzed, she couldn't get up, and the more she tried the harder it got even though she wasn't moving at all. It wasn't until she heard a scream of pure agony that a shot of adrenaline rushed through her.

Catra was screaming, Shadow Weaver was killing her just like she had promised. Adora couldn't let that happen, not again. As alive as Catra had been when Adora had found out she was gone the first time, she was dead to Adora, to the Horde, to everyone. This time, if Adora didn't get up, she'd be gone for good.

"No, no, no," Adora muttered, she didn't know if it was only inside her head that she heard it, but she could have sworn her lips moved.

As another cry fell from Catra's lips, Adora felt energy surge through her. If she couldn't help as Adora, she'd pull She-ra into this.

The magic was right at her fingertips, and it was only moments before Adora was engulfed by glowing white and gold. She could move again, and she could only gasp as the power grew inside her.

Beautiful

Catra, even on the verge of an excruciatingly painful death, could only look at Adora and think she was beautiful.

Magic flowed around her in a stunning show of both light and power, casting a soft glow on everything with a sense of revival and healing. It washed in waves against Shadow Weaver's magic which was now fizzling apart and loosening its hold on Catra.

Adora hadn't even fully transformed yet, but Catra knew it would be different from the first and only time she had seen her transform just a year earlier. She watched in awe and even missed catching herself before she hit the ground, free from Shadow Weaver's hold as She-ra struck the old woman down with nothing but light, eyes glowing with fury.

She'd never tell Adora that.

Done.

"You are done, Shadow Weaver," Adora kicked the woman in the ribs, a wheeze of pain escaping the sorceress as she scrambled away on the floor, "it's over. You have caused me- *so much pain* ," Adora cried. "Not anymore."

Behind them, Catra was watching the whole thing. She was still a little hurt, her throat hoarse and many of her ribs still ached, but Adora's transformation had healed her enough to be able to stand up and limp over to where Shadow Weaver lied.

Weak, and fragile.

Catra got close enough to hear Shadow Weaver's last words, before Adora took her newly created sword and stabbed her sword into the ground, through the witch's body.

Maybe I shouldn't have killed Hordak after all...

Glimmer and Bow

"We need to get these people away," Glimmer realized, "There's no chance we'll beat the Horde, we didn't see this coming," she relented in her fighting, focusing instead on conserving energy to teleport the villagers.

"Adora did," Bow admitted, "Adora saw this coming, and we didn't listen to her," his brows furrowed in shame.

Glimmer pursed her lips, "We don't have time for that right now, we need to evacuate, and then we'll find Adora," she scanned the battlefield, "wherever she went to."

With a sigh, Bow conceded, “Okay, let’s do this before the full force arrives.” He leaped down from his high ground, already shouting at the people and directing them towards the only entrance and exit to Thaymor. “Into the woods, people!”

In the heat of the moment, the villagers ignored the fact that these were princesses and rebellion fighters directing them, making their way towards safety without argument. When the town mayor started yelling as well, the escapee group grew larger and about half an hour later, the town was fully evacuated, even those previously trapped under rubble now being patched up by the local healers.

Just as Bow and Glimmer turned back to find Adora, a villager stopped them.

“Hey!”

Bow spoke with caution, sparing a curious look with Glimmer “...Yes?”

The man’s gaze drew to the ground, refusing to look Bow or Glimmer in the eyes, “Thank you. You helped us all get out… but that doesn’t excuse what you’ve done in the past, or what you’re going to do anyway!”

Glimmer was confused. This man was thanking them for helping, but yelling at them for… for what? “I’m sorry?”

The man's eyes narrowed, now staring straight at the two fighters with a newfound courage, "Every time. Every time you come, and you fight for us, and you beat the Horde, expecting parties and celebrations thrown in your honor. But after you receive all the glory, and the fame, you leave us to deal with the fallout," tears welled up in his eyes alongside a bitter anger and resentment, "Our homes have crumbled right before our eyes, our families and friends have died, and sometimes- the land is left uninhabitable. We're left to pick up the pieces because *you* refuse to defend against the horde until they're right at our doorstep. And you? You get to go home. You slip into a castle and under silk sheets, comfortable and warm."

Bow stared in horror, and Glimmer was left speechless. It was true and they knew it.

"I- I don't-" A yell of anger in the distance cut Glimmer off. She whipped her head around in remembrance, "Adora!"

The two rebellion fighters sprinted away, leaving the villagers to shake their heads in disappointment.

They hadn't been heard.

What?

"What did she say?" Adora whispered it, unbelieving and looking to Catra for confirmation. "Did I hear that right?"

“She killed Hordak,” Catra repeated in a hoarse whisper.

Before either of them could think more about that, Glimmer and Bow ran towards them, yelling Adora’s name in both relief and surprise at the appearance of She-ra.

“Adora! What the hell!” Glimmer demanded an explanation, “Since when did you have the sword?”

Adora paused in realization, “I didn’t.” She looked towards Catra, who was breathing shallowly. It caught the attention of Glimmer and Bow, but Adora was already moving to help her. “Hey, hey, are you okay? Catra, what’s wrong, what hurts?”

Catra slumped over in Adora’s waiting arms, *everything* hurt, Adora’s healing light from the transformation only temporarily helping. She could only groan in pain as Adora lowered her to the ground, kneeling next to her in slight panic.

“I have to heal her- I- crap!”

Wow, Catra thought, *she must be real worried if she’s swearing* she chuckled inwardly. She was probably delirious *haha* .

She felt She-ra’s trembling hands scoop her up again, and she whimpered in pain, “Sorry, I’m sorry,” Adora muttered. Catra felt the tenseness with which Adora held herself. She wouldn’t be able to do anything while this worried, much less heal. Slowly, eyes still screwed shut and throat still burning, Catra mustered up all her strength for the sake of simply giving Adora a reassuring squeeze.

She felt the blonde melt under the weak grip, and a few moments later, the same healing light from before was washing over her, stronger and more consistent.

Finally, Catra was able to slowly open her eyes, staring right into She-ra’s glowing blue eyes. The more she stared though, the more Catra realized- this really was *Adora* .

She sat up, pulling slightly out of Adora’s arms, “You’re really here,” she nearly whispered in awe.

“Yeah,” Adora choked out with a wobbly smile, and she looked ready to cry again, burying her face in her hands as sobs took over.

“I’m sorry too,” Catra clutched Adora’s arms, the both of them hugging and crying, setting a scene for the pair of rebels standing beside them and the sea of villagers returning cautiously as no more commotion was heard. "I'm still mad at you though," she sniffled.

Adora's heart plummeted into her stomach for a second, but, "Okay, yeah, yeah, that's fine." She still held on tight to Catra though, "Stars I- I thought you were dead for so long But you're not- you're here. I'm such an idiot."

Finally, Catra pulled back, cracking a smile, 'Yeah, you are. But I missed you, so much." She had tear streaks down her face to prove it.

It awed Adora. The way Catra was acting. She was the same she had always been but so much warmer. A year spent apart from each other and so much had changed, but at their core it was really just still *them* .

“You missed her?”

The two paused at the voice. *Voice **s** .*

Glimmer and Marcy had spoken at the same time.

Adora and Catra just now realized they had an audience, and while rebels and the villagers hadn’t agreed upon much when first interacting, it seemed like at least Marcy and Glimmer agreed on one thing-

Adora and Catra shouldn’t be together. Standing up, the two of them realized it when the overlapping arguments of why were

heard from both sides.

“This is what you’ve been chasing after, Adora?”

“Catra, you spent so long being distraught because of this, because of *her* .”

“ *Months* wasted because of someone from the Horde!”

“Don’t you remember the pain you went through?”

“How do you even know if you can trust her?”

“You’ve built something real, something *solid* here.”

“I just don’t want you to get hurt again.”

Catra and Adora had polar opposite reactions, and it was something neither of them expected. A shocked Adora went first.

“Excuse me?” She fixed Glimmer with an angry look, “ *You* didn’t want to listen to me when I let you all know the Horde was here. These past months have been spent predicting the Horde’s next

moves, not *wasted* . And,” she paused to look back at Catra, a decisive look firmly set before she looked back at Glimmer, “I’d trust her with my life.”

"Adora…"

"Why are you so mad about this Glimmer? I thought you wanted me to be happy?"

"Happy?!" Glimmer nearly scoffed, "You spent the first few months in the Rebellion *obsessed* with finding her, someone from the Horde no less. After that, something happened, something with this woman laying right here, next to me," she pointed down at a lifeless Shadow Weaver, "and all of a sudden you spiral into depression. You won't eat, you won't sleep, you spent all your time locked up in your room doing *who knows what* , because of *her* ." She narrowed her gaze at Catra for a second before demanding from Adora, "Is that what you call happy?!"

“No.”

Adora wasn’t backing down and Catra could see that. Standing next to Marcy, Catra realized just as Adora did that they weren’t the same as they had been a year ago. Catra didn’t know who these rebels were, and normally, she wouldn’t have cared, but the fine fabrics and shimmering armor on the purple and pink haired girl and the tall guy next to her compared to Adora’s Horde rags- She-ra now gone- and a single scratched-up gold pin made it obvious these two were important, probably more so than Adora. And Adora was defending Catra from them.

If you would have asked her a year ago if Adora would yell at two superiors for *her* , she wouldn't have been able to give a clear cut answer. She wasn't sure if she'd be able to say *yes* . Now, analyzing the way Adora's stance seemed defensive and angled so that she blocked Catra from 'Glimmer', Catra was leaning more and more towards that yes. It's not like she couldn't defend herself, but she felt she had already proven that.

It was time to let *Adora* prove if she still cared.

Happy.

"No, that's not what I call 'happy', Glimmer. I was fucking *miserable* . Because I thought Catra was dead. I thought the- I thought my best friend was dead and all everyone could worry about was *She-ra* . Even now, I have her back and all you're worried about is the fact that I *missed* Catra."

"She's from the *Horde* , Adora-"

"So what!" Adora snapped.

"We can't trust her! Bow, back me up here," but Bow stayed quiet, carefully inspecting his surroundings. It was out of character for him. He wasn't coming to the defense of either of his friends and Adora had really thought he would sympathize for a stray Horde defector.

Maybe he just hadn't decided yet.

"And you know what I think," Glimmer's tone was near smug now, and Adora raised her head in suspicion while backing up towards Catra, still blocking her from Glimmer's view. "I think she's been training the villagers. They clearly had enough experience to hold their own and that's never happened before," the rebel commander sounded falsely innocent in her accusations, and it was unsettling to Adora. She was treating it like a casual conversation. "Why do you think that is? Why would a *Horde soldier* be training the first group of people she could get her hands on?"

And you?

Adora's eye's narrowed dangerously. Without a second's hesitation- as if she had been waiting to spill the truth for a long, long time- she spoke, "And what have you done, Glimmer? What have *you* done for these people? Help?" Adora scoffed.

"You rescued 'She-ra' after she chased away the Horde, after *I* left this place trashed and we teleported away! I was so busy worrying about other things that I forgot about an entire *village* . I *forgot* . That's on me," she admitted without an inch of uncertainty.

"But the alliance, the *Rebellion* keeps leaving people unguarded and when their towns fall apart, when you pop in to save them, you expect them to thank you? To join the fight?" With an

incredulous laugh she waved towards Catra, "At least *she's* teaching them to fend for themselves! She's doing more than any of us have done! So don't you *dare* judge her for doing better in a few months than you have in your entire time of command."

She was huffing in anger by the end of her rant, and she could see Glimmer seething with anger and humiliation, but Adora couldn't keep her mouth shut any longer and neither Glimmer nor Bow had a response.

Good.

"If you would just *trust me* , I can prove that Catra isn't trying to hurt anyone. This- *this problem* , of leaving things halfway done, we need to fix it Glimmer," Adora pleaded.

For a second, she thought Glimmer might start yelling again, or storm off, but instead, she took a deep breath, bowed her head, and quietly admitted, "You're right."

Shocked, Adora was left speechless.

"You're right Adora, and I'm… I'm sorry." Glimmer looked around at the audience of villagers surrounding her. "You all tried to tell us about this before, in the forest, but I didn't listen and, I'm sorry for that," she looked towards Adora again, "I'm sorry it took so long for me to see that, I'm sorry it took me so long to trust you," she sighed, "I'm sorry for a lot of things. Mom always says

we’re supposed to listen to what the people have to say and… I haven’t been doing that. I’ve been focusing so much on fighting, on trying to end this war that I was ready to pin the blame on anyone.” She stepped forward and looked past Adora, “I’m sorry for that too, Catra.”

Watched.

Marcy watched the princesses listen for once. She had watched She-ra speak up for them all, defending Catra and convincing the princess of Brightmoon to admit she was wrong.

It was a feat unheard of, and Marcy wondered what else this young woman could do. Who was she really? Who was she to Catra?

It was more complicated than simply the one who broke her heart, Marcy knew that now, as did the entire village.

But what did Catra know?

Chapter End Notes

> I'm not dead! I really do want to apologize aside from the long wait, the fact that I hadn't replied to some of your guys' comments on the last chapter. I promise, I read all of them, and I think reading and responding to comments is half the fun of writing fanfics, but when I saw how many there were, and the realization that school is taking up ALL my time, I had to choose between spending an hour replying to comments, or an hour getting a few more sentences in the

new chapter, and after about a week, I figured it was too late to respond. I promise though, if anyone comments on this chapter, I WILL comment back. Uhh, not sure when the next update will be either...

If ya'll haven't forgotten me, thanks for reading, and thank you for your patience!

I'm sorry.

Chapter Summary

> They say sorry. Adora's a crybaby. We get one of my favorite tropes but I don't actually know what it's called. I'm just going to call it... exposing? You guess. Let me know later if you want.
>
> **TW for very few mentions of depression, dissociation, and uhh anxiety?** I think that's it. Short. No beta. (Unfortunately)

Chapter Notes

> I hate finals. I hate people. Actually, hate is a very strong word so I'll replace it with "don't like". Doesn't have the same spice though, does it?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra cleared her throat awkwardly. It seemed everyone and their mother was expecting her to respond to Glimmer's apology. But what could she say, really? She hardly knew this… princess, aside from the fact that she had stormed into her home, accused her of something that was probably a war crime, got yelled at, and not two minutes later was apologizing for the accusation.

It was disorienting, but the expectant look on everyone's face prompted an only half thought-out answer. "While I don't appreciate what you said," she paused only to watch the girl's face start to fall, "I think, maybe if we continue talking about how the rebellion has been dealing with all these villages and the fall of the Horde now, you'll have made it up to me," she finished with a (tiny, just tiny) smirk.

Helping the villagers had always been the goal after all. The Horde being on the brink of collapse was just a useful coincidence.

At the same time, Catra realized the position she had put herself in. She was going to have to *keep* interacting with 'Glimmer', and Catra assumed she wasn't quite at the top of the food chain. Would she have to leave Thaymor to help them? It wasn't something she had planned, much less wanted, but as the villagers smiled at the implication of the deal, Catra knew she wouldn't back out. Maybe she could work something out. None of this would happen overnight, after all.

As the crowd dispersed and Adora kept *staying* , Catra noticed the distance and slight tension that still sizzled between Adora and Glimmer.

Glimmer, Glimmer, Glimmer. She kept repeating the name in her head but every time she looked at her, all Catra could think of was 'Sparkles'. How could she not? The girl was the embodiment of them in everything but personality.

Catra had already forgotten the guys' name, but she wondered if the same could apply to him when he spoke up, likely hoping to relieve the same tension Catra felt, "Hey, have you heard of a wood carving shop here? We came looking to find some tiny figurines!"

Catra visibly lit up, forgetting about everything else, "Yeah," she felt Marcy lingering a few feet away but ignored her for the

moment before admitting a bit shyly, “that’s my shop, actually.” The trios’ brows rose in astonishment, and Catra found herself slightly offended, “What? I gotta do *something* around here.” She turned swiftly and marched towards her shop, listening to the way the three behind her stumbled over themselves to catch up after realizing she had left them in the dust.

When Catra finally reached the door, the memories of all the items in the shop flooded back into her mind. In her haste to get Adora and Glimmer more amiable, she had forgotten about the one thing that had refused to leave her mind for a year: Adora.

Not the one standing behind her, eager as Catra remembered her to be even with an underlying sense of draining *sadness* , but the figurine of Adora displayed in the corner of the shop, meant to torment Catra for days and remind her of why she was where she was- until now.

And the circle, the damned random circle drawn on the floor that one of the three was bound to ask about, Catra just knew it. And she couldn’t lie. She had just gotten Adora back and she wasn’t going to start off lying.

Seconds passed, and Catra realized she had paused at the doorway for too long, her hand lingering on the doorknob that had taken her a week to make because she didn’t know how a lock functioned. Stars, this entire *shop* was an exhibit of her feelings and actions from the past year. How could she forget that? Forget the nights she spent screaming and crying out of frustration because she was *alone.*

Well, here goes nothing , she thought, as she finally pulled through and twisted the knob, pushing the door open to reveal her entire self to these strangers, because as much as she knew Adora, a lot had happened to the both of them in a year, and she was a bit unpredictable.

The first thing Catra caught sight of was the state of some of the walls.

It was common knowledge that sometimes, especially before she got steady, she'd throw little fits of anger here and there in which the walls of her very own store would suffer the wrath of her claws. Her defense was, "better the walls than a person".

But she and the people of Thaymor stared at these walls every day. It was normal to see scratches, new and old. Catra knew the story behind them. But now, with three brand new people in here, it was hard to deny that none of the parts of her store looked particularly normal.

She cleared her throat, "So uh, is there anything you're looking for, or?"

Bow seemed to be the only one to perk up at that, the other two in the room simply looking around and inspecting everything, especially Adora.

"Yeah actually! I wanted to put in an order of tiny figurines," Bow pulled out a bunch of pictures of people Catra didn't recognize but knew enough of to put together that they were princesses. *Magical* princesses. Even a few horde soldiers popped out, basic cadets with their helmets and uniforms on.

Catra tilted her head in confusion, "So, what's this for?"

"Ah, just some battle planning figures. I realized I didn't have everyone but if I was going to get new figures I wanted them all to match, so I just came for a whole new set."

"Wait," Catra paused, squinting at Bow's face as they stood across from each other on the counter, Bow himself feeling a bit self-conscious, "you look exactly like these two dudes that came in a few weeks ago, one is overly preppy- like you, but the other was more," Catra couldn't quite think of the right word.

"Battle-hardened?" Bow interrupted her thoughts, and as Catra looked Bow up and down, she found that he had some of those same features in him, overcast by his blinding smile and cheeriness.

"Yeah…"

Adora was wandering around the entire store.

It didn’t look too big from the outside, and she was pretty sure it wasn’t as big as it seemed to be from the insider, but there was just so much to *look at.*

She went from corner to corner, her neck twisting and turning to look at everything from the floor to the ceiling where she found a nice, dark corner in the rafters. The darkness itself continued descending down the corner from top to bottom, a weird anomaly in which the section remained shadowy no matter how much light there was around.

Huh.

Eventually, she found herself drawn to the right side of the store, nearer to the counter where Bow was showing Catra his tiny Bow figurine. There was a larger statue of sorts, and the closer she got to it, the quicker she realized,

“It’s me.”

Adora had whispered it in a sort of awe and horror, but Catra heard it anyway, and the silence in the room that followed let everyone hear Catra’s nervous gulp.

Adora lifted a hand, her fingertips gently running over the immaculate detail of who she was before the rebellion, before *this* , her own dead and hopeless eyes staring into the naive, forgetful ones of the statue before her.

“Adora,” Catra started, but not before a gasp of air escaped Adora in a subdued *sob* , her tears welling up at the realization.

“What have I done,” Adora rasped in a hoarse whisper, “I *left* you here and you- you still,” her head whipped around to look at Catra, her brows furrowed in confusion, “you still remembered me? You still cared about me? I- I-”

“Of course I cared about you!” Catra finally snapped, her own welled-up tears now streaming down her face, “I still do! What? Did you think that just because I didn’t follow you around like a damn pet, like an *animal* , I don’t care about you?!”

“I thought you didn’t care because *I didn’t stay!”*

That shut Catra up.

“I should have stayed,” Adora cried, “but I didn’t and you should *hate* me for that. I asked you to come with me, somewhere not even *I* knew about,” Adora was waving her arms around now, almost erratically, “I asked you to leave our *home* , as bad as that place was. And when you said no to a question I didn’t have a right to ask,” her eyes stared off into space as if remembering the moment she had last seen Catra before this, “ *I left you* .” Adora’s vision focused again on Catra’s shocked face, whispering almost devotedly for something she had believed for *months,* “And then you died…”

Glimmer saw the collapse coming before Adora herself.

"Adora," she called out in warning right as Adora stumbled back. She teleported over to help Adora right herself again, the worry in Catra's eyes clear as it seemed this was a new development for Adora.

It was something that had changed and it made Catra all more aware of the fact that they had been separated for a year, and they didn't know each other as well as they should have.

"Adora, sit down," Glimmer insisted, pushing down on Adora's shoulders in an attempt to get her knees to finally buckle and slide down to the floor.

"No, no, I have to- It's not okay, I need to explain-"

"Adora," Catra finally shook out of her stupor and moved in front of Adora, nearly taking her face into her hands but choosing to simply hover them in restrained care, "we can talk about this whenever you want, as long as you want because stars know I have some things to tell you too, but I need you to calm down first. Can you do that for me?"

Soon enough, Adora was back to a fully aware and calm state, maybe a little worn out, but not enough to keep from asking Catra to let her continue their 'talk', which had truly been more of a screaming match between the two, but Adora persevered.

In the face of such insistence, Catra relented, and led Adora by the hand to a secluded part of the woods, a place she knew well, leaving Bow and Glimmer behind in her shop.

Unexpected

"That was…" Bow started, he and Glimmer exiting out of the shop, "unexpected." Being inside there without Catra felt wrong.

"Was it though? I mean, everyone in Brightmoon knew Adora had lost someone important to her, the way she'd been acting for so long, it makes sense that she'd act this way now with Catra." Glimmer should have seen this coming, they *all* should have. Was Adora even going to want to leave Catra now? Would she return to Brightmoon?

Her spiral of thoughts was interrupted when her eye caught the supposed town Mayor, Marcy, already helping in the reconstruction of the few homes that had sustained damage during the Horde attack.

"Excuse me," she borrowed a much more polite tone than her usual demanding one, "Marcy?"

The older woman turned, leaving whatever was occupying her in the hands of a younger, more energetic looking man.

“Yes,” Marcy paused, “Commander Glimmer?”

Glimmer gulped. She couldn’t help but feel a bit intimidated by this woman.

She was no stranger to an older woman standing her ground- her own mother was stubborn when it came to letting Glimmer do *anything* - but as her daughter she knew she could get away with things, a grounding being the only threat of punishment. Somehow, she knew Marcy wouldn’t let her pull the same tricks here.

But Glimmer was curious, and she couldn’t help her gaze being drawn to the buckets of wooden staffs and other makeshift weapons at the center of the village. After a few seconds, Bow and Marcy’s gazes were drawn there as well, and Marcy stared at the now scuffed and cracked weapons Catra had made for them before facing Glimmer again, waiting.

“I just wanted to know…” Marcy’s brow raised, prompting her, “why trust Catra?”

Marcy scoffed, already annoyed at Glimmer’s line of questioning, “You doubt-”

“No, no, no,” the princess waved her hands around, “that’s not what I meant. I mean, when Catra first came here, she was still dressed like a Horde soldier, right? And right after an attack? There was no reason why you all should’ve let her stay.”

Out of the corner of her eye, Glimmer saw Bow nodding his head along in assent.

In the back of her mind, Marcy knew the commander was right. As mayor, she should have gotten rid of the girl from the moment they saw her. A horde soldier had to have been hostile, right? But, she sighed, “You didn’t see her a year ago. Even just a few months less than that,” the mayor shook her head in remembrance. “She was so vulnerable,” staring into Glimmer’s eyes, *hoping* she would understand, she spoke the last word, “broken.”

“What do you mean,” Bow stepped closer, his head tilting with the question.

Marcy hesitated. The state Catra had been in, the state of such grief and loss and *confusion* was something she knew Catra would never share with anyone not close to her- and even then, she wasn’t exactly an open book with the people of Thaymor, people whom she loved dearly.

Even so, the princess and the archer would never understand Catra nor the townspeople if they simply assumed.

For a second, Marcy mourned the feeling of having knowledge above that of a noble, and she started.

"Catra was incredibly distraught when the battle of Thaymor ended. When her friend, *Adora* , left. With you two," she stared pointedly at them. "We were still hiding in the forest, but once we returned Catra returned as well. As you said," she reminded Glimmer, "we were wary of her at first. But she walked past everyone. Didn't even seem to notice we were there."

The pair's eyebrows crinkled in confusion, "What??"

Marcy nodded, "that was, until she simply collapsed in the middle of the town. If you go into her shop, you'll notice a circle. That's exactly where she sat. For *weeks* ."

Bow himself seemed to recall the circle. It had seemed a menial thing to him at first, however, he now realized the importance of it. "Wait, weeks? Did she ever get up to eat, drink, anything?"

"Hardly," Marcy responded almost casually, but inside she was heartbroken. She remembered seeing Catra sitting in that invisible cage day and night. She hadn't known her as well back then, but she knew that if it ever happened to Catra now, she'd never let it go on that long. "She got up sometimes, drinking and eating just enough to survive, but she was deadly thin."

Bow and Glimmer could only stare in horror. Marcy could see their minds working to conjure up the image. It wasn't a pretty one.

"It wasn't until one day, she suddenly left, going into the Whispering Woods for a while to do who knows what, but she returned healthier, a bit more aware, and with a newfound skill. It was only a bit later that she started to help with the reconstruction, and after that permission to build her shop."

"All on her own?" Glimmer could hardly believe it.

"All on her own," Marcy smiled proudly, though a bit saddened by the thought that Catra believed she *had* to do it all by herself.

Bow and Glimmer themselves were recalling Adora's reaction to Catra's supposed 'death'. They remembered Adora's depression, her anger, her draining grief. From what they gathered, Catra had gone through something similar. To think that she had dealt with it all by herself.

It was shocking, to say the least.

The two started to understand just a fraction more the dynamic between Catra and Adora.

Sorry

Catra sat the two of them down in the same spot she had realized she could learn to wood carve. It was a bit of a vulnerable spot for her, but Adora herself made Catra more vulnerable than ever. She couldn't avoid that even with avoiding Adora.

Adora though, Adora chuckled, "I remember seeing this tree and thinking you were close by. Guess I was more right than I thought."

Catra couldn't help narrow her eyes, muttering, "Guess you were."

Hearing the tone, Adora lowered her head, "I'm sorry I didn't look for you. Better, *more* ."

Immediately, Catra shook her own head, "It wouldn't have done us any good, Adora. Even if you had found me earlier," Catra remembered all the anger she held, whether it be towards Adora or not, "I don't know how I would have reacted."

"What? Why?" Adora tensed, feeling that maybe she still hadn't registered Catra's willingness to talk the right way.

"I was angry, Adora. For a long time," Catra confessed. "I mean I tore up this tree. A *lot* of trees just wondering if you leaving was my fault, or your fault, or *no one's* fault!" She got up to pace. "I spent *weeks* before that, *waiting* for you to come back," she nearly cried, and the words did the same to Adora, "but you never did. And I never went to look either, so."

Catra shrugged her shoulders in resignation, acceptance.

Immediately, Adora rose to stand against her, “It was *not* your fault Catra. *I* left *you* , got it?”

“Did you?”

“What? It’s obvious, Catra. I left. You stayed here. You didn’t even go back to the Horde!”

Wanting to leave the topic, Catra shrugged her shoulders and let her eyes slip closed, but Adora wasn’t having it. “I’m sorry. I know I’ve said it a lot of times, but I really mean it and I don’t know how to make sure you know it.”

“I know Adora, trust me, I do. I’m sorry too. I think we left each other, honestly. I mean, it’s not like I *didn’t* reject you when you asked me to go with you. I could have said yes. I could have followed you. Even after I said no I could have looked-"

"But why would you, Catra? You probably felt so betrayed."

"But you were right about leaving the Horde Adora!” Catra’s claws waved around as she made wide and desperate gestures, “Why

would *you* want to go back? Why would *I* want to go back? Even with me there… it would have been hell for the both of us."

"Maybe you're right," Adora finally admitted, "but I still think the decision I made was too fast. I mean I left, popped back up in a random town, and said we should just go toddle away with some random rebels? It went against everything we had together, and when I went back for you I should have known-"

"It was bound to happen someday, Adora. You would have realized what the Horde was doing eventually," Catra reassured.

Adora winced in shame again with the reminder of Catra's life in the Horde. "I'm sorry I didn't notice sooner, didn't notice what they were doing to you, how much you were going through."

"I know." Catra was over the pity, "But Adora, I don't think you've even realized how much Shadow Weaver manipulated us, not just with my supposed death, it was *all the time.* "

"I'm still sorry."

"...I am too, just please, Adora, don't leave me again," she pleaded

"I won't, I won't I-"

"Adora," Catra said warningly, tiredly. Tired of broken promises.

"I promise Catra, I won't leave you again."

"Bullshit!" Anger rose in her. The denial came flooding back.

Adora rushed to grab her hands, tears once again, for the hundredth time that day, streaming down her cheeks, "I can't. I can't leave you, Catra, not even if I wanted to, I couldn't bear it. If you want me to go, I'll still fight like hell to stick around but, if you really want me gone- Stars, I just- please- I can't, I can't," she nearly begged.

And Catra was tired of broken promises.

But not tired enough to make more, it seemed.

"Stay."

Chapter End Notes

Yay, they're finally back together and nothing's going to rip them apart ever again because they PROMISED. :)

Promises are WEAK. Haha just kidding, just kidding
...

By the way Adora does collapse because of her anxiety if you were wondering. Any other questions you can just ask in the comments if you want because there's probably a lot I missed here.
I wanted to post this the week of thanksgiving but someone had to borrow my laptop and maybe you guys don't remember the shitshow that happened when I wrote on my Ipad but I do and it's not happening again :)

Again, sorry for taking so long and not posting much. I promise if I ever post anything not for this work, it's been prewritten and sitting in my docs for over 6 months or it took like 15 minutes to write. Thank you for your patience if you're still here haha. I don't hate this chapter so much so maybe you liked it? See you... next month? Next year? Let's hope for the former.

End with New Beginnings

Chapter Summary

Things seem to have settled down but they're just getting started.

Chapter Notes

TECHNICALLY... it is before the new year. So.
It is reallllyyy short though.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They were back in the town now. After having spent a while more in the woods, laughing, crying, *smiling* , Catra felt more and more assured by the second. Things felt like they had back in the Horde, but better because they were safer, more open, more *them* .

It was the most Catra could wish for, but of course Sparkles had to come over and burst their overly fragile bubble.

“We have to get back to Brightmoon. The Horde is in a power vacuum right now, and we need to tell my mom about the towns, the places that aren’t secured, She-ra-”

Just when the pit of unease had begun to settle back into Catra’s stomach, Adora spoke up, “I don’t want to tell Angella about She-ra yet. I don’t want to go back yet.”

A look of shock had overtaken Glimmer's face for a second, but with a bit more time of looking at the pair's faces, it was replaced by a look of understanding. It was weird to Catra, but she would take it if it meant Adora could stay. "Okay. I'll let her know that you want to be the representative for the town of Thaymor and all the other small towns alongside Catra and Marcy if they're okay with that." It was quick thinking on Glimmer's part.

Without a doubt, Marcy nodded her consent.

Catra though, she hesitated. "Me? I don't really know anything about… politics and stuff."

The commander reassured her though, "It's not just politics. You'll be in charge of guarding towns like these alongside General Juliet of Brightmoon," her formal tone dropped into something more amiable, "besides, I think you'll do well in discussing things with the other delegates. You fit the job, if you want it."

Adora squeezed Catra's hand in support, "And I get to stay here?" Glimmer nodded in confirmation.

"Aside from a meeting every 6 months and maybe a few more spread in between, yeah. Adora would be doing the same too."

Catra agreed then, "Okay I'll do it."

Glimmer beamed, squealing in delight. “Great! Come on Bow!”

All eyes were on them. Again.

Catra supposed she should have expected this. She knew Thaymor was a small town, and she knew rumors and gossip here spread like wildfire. At the same time that fire felt like it was scalding her hand, the one gripping Adora’s relentlessly.

Was she ashamed?

This was her- her *family* , after all. And she knew they wouldn’t quite approve of Adora, at least not Marcy, not yet.

As much as talk of the Battle of Thaymor had been kept from her, to protect her, to protect her *feelings* , there was no avoiding the common opinion that She-ra and the rebellion had wrecked the place, only pushing further the gospel of the community that went against the monarchy of the princesses and their way of ruling- or rather, their *lack* of ruling. And Adora, eight feet tall or not, was a princess. *The* princess.

And unspoken between the two was that love that made Catra suffer so. And as recently learned, made Adora suffer as well.

With that thought came Catra's question: How could something so strong, so intricate, so… charming, be the root of such great pain and grief?

The grief that everyone in this town saw, the backlash from some would be inevitable, Catra realised as she led her and Adora back to her shop. It was the only semi-private place here that wasn't in the woods. And while a part of Catra wanted to go out and show off Adora like she had just found her favorite newly carved piece, she couldn't. She would wait.

Wait until she and Adora were both more comfortable, the townsfolk were more comfortable, and Marcy was more comfortable. She was reintroducing two separate pieces of her world and she wasn't going to let them clash and crumble apart.

It was crumbling.

Oh, it was all falling apart, like sand running through the gaps between her fingers, slipping away and she couldn't catch it.

It was only the first day, the first *night.* She and Adora had been practically attached to the hip and yet Drint still wormed his way between them.

Drint, whom she felt she hadn't seen in years when really it hadn't even been a week.

“She spent a little over a month in that circle, you know?”

Stars, she should have known he’d visit the shop even on such an eventful day, if only just to *see* Adora. Even being the town’s nemesis of sorts, She-ra was still a legend. After that came Adora, the woman who had hurt Catra, as they saw it.

Catra herself had already told Adora about the circle, but being in front of it, having someone who *saw* Catra at her worst describe it from an outsider’s point of view in heavy detail after that first sentence, mentioning almost casually how she, “looked like death itself, something so hurt and empty even after,” all while circling the blonde next to Catra like a shark.

It nearly made Adora cry again. She would have, if not for the fact that Catra was tired, *exhausted* of the tears, the looking back, the fear, when they could focus on the now and on the future.

On the other hand, Catra had no idea Drint could be so… manipulative, petty. It scared her. What else could these seemingly kind people do?

No. ‘Seemingly kind’ was wrong. Catra knew these people. She *knew* they were kind. It was only natural that they could behave in a manner other than innocence and gossip. She couldn’t expect them to only act one way. It would be hypocritical of her. She also couldn’t expect what would come, either.

It was only the morning after an awkward and tentative reunion, Adora sleeping in Catra's bed while trying not to take up space but simultaneously wanting to hold the woman she loved in her arms and giving up after an annoyed but warm, "Just come 'ere, dork," with Catra opening her arms in invitation. Yes, the morning after, it seemed everyone had voted overnight- without Catra's vote- that Adora had to help with the very, *very* minimal reconstruction efforts of the day. And Catra, well Catra was assigned the very long but truly unnecessary task of collecting berries for the winter.

It was spring.

Would the berries even be ripe?

What was clear out of the entire ordeal was that the town wanted the two separated. They couldn't do it forever but they could do it for the day and by the way Catra was dragged off in a group of other fake berry-pickers and Adora was dragged away by Marcy, they weren't going to take no for an answer.

Sindan again.

Again he was working on the town's reconstruction. Though this time was less labor intensive, he was outside standing in the sun again and going back to this after the high of kicking some Horde butt was discouraging.

He did take the opportunity, however, to watch how the new girl interacted with people.

She was clumsy, he could tell you that after watching her trip over rubble for the third time. Maybe she wasn't always clumsy though, because he saw the way her steps became calculated and serious when the time came to push up a piece of… a house, he assumed.

She never turned into She-ra either. Maybe it was because she knew how much of a sore spot it was for the people, but Sindan thought it was a stupid move because she could have cleaned up ten times faster if she had turned into a super tall warrior instead of working her own not-so-flimsy arms.

He was grateful for the thought though.

He wondered if she was as good a fighter as Catra. General civilians didn't know much about She-ra, or Adora, he supposed. But the way she had stood up for them to Commander Glimmer told him she was either from the Horde or the Crimson Waste, and that prim ponytail, boots, and jacket *screamed* Horde. She didn't carry a staff though. Even with She-ra's sword missing from her person he knew she could likely just say the magic words and completely obliterate them.

Sindan, leaned against a decently sturdy wall, found himself imagining a giant golden boot crushing him when he saw Riso

nearing ‘Adora’, their actually-flimsy arms struggling to push a wall up next to her.

It took Sindan a couple of times before he realized it was a test.

A test of what? Sindan didn’t have the most accurate interpretation, but Riso knew. They always did.

The wall test.

In all honesty, it took them a while to find a partially intact wall that was heavy enough to make them struggle. Riso wasn’t very strong, but they made their way through life just fine, 74 years and counting. They decided they were going to use that lack of strength for something good. Not very often no, but the times it did happen, counted for more than one could imagine.

When Catra had first taken the test, everyone but Riso was surprised. They had sensed a good in her that couldn’t be ignored and they proved it. *Catra* proved it when she looked past all the rubble in the village, spotted the person who needed her, and helped.

What was important was the *way* she helped. Even at her low point, Catra was willing to put that aside not only to prove herself, to prove that she had gained back her strength, to prove that she

was *worth* something, but to prove- unknowingly- that she was always looking to be there.

Catra could have left after regaining her strength and part of herself, but she came trudging back to this little town anyway and helped put it back together.

It was complicated, yes, and there were exceptions and changes and a lot of things done to the test for each person. But in the six times Riso had done it, it had never failed them. Riso wouldn't judge before the test was done.

Perhaps some people thought them a lunatic, or a fraud. The test seemed too broad to actually count as anything other than simply having a person push up a wall.

But when Adora dropped what she was doing to help the trembling old person, pulled Riso aside after to make sure they were okay, and very nearly ordered them to stop working as Adora could take care of it, Riso knew this wasn't just for show.

Adora wasn't being good for Catra, or even for the people. She could have left Riso to pull up the wall alone. She could have helped and then walked away.

Could have, could have, could have. Because Catra wasn't here and these people weren't quite connected to Adora yet. Could have. But she didn't.

Without a word spoken to either of them, Riso felt they knew Catra and Adora very well.

Berries.

Katya, Olive, and Drint were the fake team Catra had been sent out with and she was itching for a little confrontation with one of them in particular.

"What was that, Drint?" They had been trekking through the woods for quite some time now and Catra knew they were going in circles because after not one berry had been found they passed the same clawed-up tree seven times. She was done. And yet, Drint still played dumb.

"What was what?"

"You know what I mean," Catra sighed and stopped, the whole group stopping with her, "I finally get back the person who makes me happiest and you try to chase her away?"

"Ooooh, you jealous, Drint?" Olive may have been as old as Marcy but she still *loved* drama.

Ignoring her, Drint fires back, “Happiest? She broke your heart,” Katya hums in agreement, “and now she’s forgiven just like that? We don’t even know what she’s like.”

“Don’t say she’s an assassin-”

“She could be an assassin for all we know!”

Catra sighs, and Katya can see the tiredness. Catra was so tired now. Her lips formed a thin line, already knowing what Drint was going to say.

“Do *you* even know her?”

Katya sighed. There it was. And she hadn’t even said anything yet.

“Of course I know her! I grew up with her!”

And that was news. To Drint and Olive but not Katya because remember: she knows that kind of heartbreak.

Catra had nearly screamed it with tears in her eyes. Tears she would never let fall, not in front of them. But she was tired and she showed it through anger. “You say these things as if I don’t

know the pain I went through! I know what I felt because it hurt like a bitch and it still does sometimes," her throat was becoming hoarse from all the crying and screaming these past few days. Drint could only lean back, caught off guard but Catra didn't stop and Olive looked around the woods awkwardly. "She came back. She explained, and we talked. I'm not some lovesick *fool* , Drint. I'm hurt. She's hurt. We made mistakes but we're *past that now* even though it seems like the whole damn town wants to hold a grudge *for me* . I just want to be with her. We lost so much time. Too much."

And with that one sentence it's like Katya can see all of Catra's and Adora's life. Together. Running around happily and oblivious as kids and they grow up and realize life isn't butterflies and rainbows.

Katya can't imagine anything after that. She's never had her Adora come back.

And even though she feels she's been on Catra's side all along, she feels like she's on Adora's side too now. Adora came back. Maybe it wasn't her intention. But she stayed. So far.

Katya thinks her standards are a little low but it's better for her, for Catra, than anything else.

She leans herself a little more towards Catra.

Another.

A beautiful one this time, Jack thinks. A year older and in a more sturdy house, he looks out his bedroom window again and can't help but admire the scene. There's a familiar figure, one who was once bathed in moonlight that enhanced her tears but is now gently illuminated by that same light, paired with a shining smile. There's a new figure next to her. They sit hunched over, whispering and giggling into the night where everyone can hear but Jack is the only one listening.

There's an 'I love you' whispered in there somewhere. And a reply.

The sight was one of a fire rekindling, one that hadn't quite been put out, and only needed the storming winds around it to calm to finally grow and release embers of happiness.

It was contagious and Jack wondered how anyone could ignore it.

He still didn't know if that torturous, paralyzing pain before this was something he'd want to go through, but as he saw two careless souls in front of him, he thought maybe it was worth it if he got to reach this point of complete freedom.

Oof.

Adora was actually getting along with a few of the villagers. She had been worried the day before when she and Catra separated, but she could survive without her for a few hours. The villagers actually proved to be significantly kinder to her when she told Riso to stop working. The dirty looks previously sent her way disappeared. There wasn't much acknowledgment either… but still.

It was only until Marcy approached her that her nerves came back full force. She knew Marcy was the town Mayor, a newly elected representative, and based on earlier interactions, close with Catra.

She reminded Adora of Angella when she first arrived at Brightmoon. Perhaps even a tad more hostile, what with the way everyone around her quieted once Marcy stepped into Adora's view amidst the rubble. A wordless request, *demand* , had Adora gulping and following Marcy to her house with her metaphorical tail tucked between her legs.

A short walk and soon they found themselves stepping inside the home, and Adora realized she was now in even less neutral territory.

"Why are you here?"

Marcy's question confused Adora.

“You brought me here?”

The older woman took one look at the blondes’ furrowed brows and couldn’t help but mumble, “Stupid as well,” only serving to make Adora blush in embarrassment.

“I know I hurt her,” Adora interjected, surprising Marcy, “I hurt a lot of the people here.”

“And yet you came back and you stayed. Knowing that your very existence is a sore spot for Catra.”

That one made Adora wince, but she also knew a lot of things that Marcy didn’t.

She wants me to stay

She wanted to say. But she knew Marcy wouldn’t budge with something as simple as that. Not when it spilled from Adora’s lips.

Words would mean nothing. Much to her delight, Adora found that this woman worked in a way similar to that of Catra’s mentality.

Words, prayers, *promises* - were hollow. An empty, meaningless thing.

Actions .

Now that she could work with. Adora might not have quite been a woman of her word. But she could translate everything she did into something with meaning. If only for Catra to be reassured.

With that, Adora's hum of eureka piercing the silence between the two, she nodded and turned on her heel to exit the house without another word to Marcy.

She might have been offended by that, but Adora knew.

She knew now

She would get this woman to like her if it was the last thing she did. For Catra.

"What do you think?"

A growled response.

"Hmm, you're right, we need a symbol… a friendly face. We need someone more…amiable, but still tough enough to make sure nobody comes around and tries to be Hordak 2.0"

Another growl, lower this time.

“She *is* a good candidate. What’dya think Kyle?”

“Oh! Uh, I’ve only met her a few times, but she seems nice enough.”

“It’s settled then, we’ve got a meeting with Scorpia today.”

Chapter End Notes

Ha.
This is more of an ending chapter for the first section of this. It's why I tried to mimic the formatting of the first chapter, but it was less... sad. It's also why it was so short. I know I seemed to have set up a lot of stuff in these previous chapters, but really I have absolutely no outline. Therefore, what do YOU want to see in upcoming chapters? It can go along the lines of what I have just with more detail, OR we can go completely off the rails if that's something suggested and if I'm up to it. (please tell me I'm desperate).

I might post some other unrelated stuff between that time from here to the next chapter, just so I can take a break from the sadness before I go back into the angst if you guys want that. (Forgive me, please, I beg of you)

See you next year!

Push and Shove

Chapter Summary

In case the state of their relationship wasn't clear...

Chapter Notes

In my defense, I did say updates would be inconsistent...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Anyone around town could see that Catra was still hesitant. Aside from all the ever-present elements of their relationship that was so complex, there was something else that complicated things for Catra and Adora.

It was in the way that they roughhoused and tumbled through the dirt like little kids, like *best friends* , and then they moved on to staring deep into each other's eyes in a way that could make even the most bitter and lonely of people believe in true love. Every single of their interactions flowed that way, there was no in between. They were the entire ocean and each and every observer was struggling to keep up with the drowning, foamy, dark waves that later became so calming you could fall asleep to the sound of them crashing down.

Drint was already shipwrecked. He couldn't keep pace with the two girls and he was starting to realize Catra and Adora couldn't either.

It took a day of him watching them to finally realize it. He had seen Catra endure such a heavy, broken heart, he watched as she

gently took Adora's hand in her own and leaned into any touch the blonde provided… and yet Catra was scared to do more. She wanted it, Drint knew solely because she had called herself- or rather, *denied* - being a lovesick fool.

They were way past best friends. But were they girlfriends? Drint thought so initially, but Adora held a pained look on her face whenever Catra turned away like she *wanted* Catra to lean into the touch, hold her closer, just *go for it, Catra.*

But alas, they were both cowards. They couldn't keep up and they didn't know what they were.

The dilemma of two ex-Horde soldiers who weren't quite familiar with the feelings of happiness and love.

Something New

"Sooo," Adora started timidly as she and Catra strolled through the town early in the morning, "wanna do something later today? Maybe go out… find some rocks…" her eyes shifted back and forth between Catra's eyes and anything else in the distance, her hands fidgeting behind her.

"What, like on a date?" Adora's eyes nearly popped out with surprise, but she found herself delighted.

"Yeah! A date. Yeah," she nodded enthusiastically. Bow and Glimmer had taught her the meaning of date when they found out the Horde didn't very eagerly allow relationships. She found herself pleasantly reassured to know she and Catra had gone on several dates now.

"You just spend a nice time with a person you love, maybe you go out to grab a bite, go shopping together, go on a walk."

"So like, just looking up at the sky with them, or looking for cool stuff to keep or give to each other, could that be a date?"

"Yeah, sure!"

"So, what do you want to do? I mean, what *can* we do," Adora asked while dragging her and Catra back to her shop. It felt like a good spot to plan things without everyone hearing, which Adora now knew was incredibly likely.

"We don't have to sneak around out here, Adora," and that made her determined steps falter.

It seemed unrealistic. "We don't?"

Catra recalled the villagers' opinions of their relationship, but she didn't think any of their disapproval could compare to the harsh punishments threatened by Shadow Weaver if Adora and Catra

really spent time on themselves for a… loving motive. “No, this isn’t the Horde. We can just do something relaxing, yeah?”

The blonde paused, taking the words in, “Okay, okay, I can work with that! Don’t worry,” she neared the entrance of the woodcarving shop, opened the door, and lightly shoved Catra into a chair, “I’ll take care of everything. You just stay here.”

And she was out of the door before Catra could protest. It took her about 5 steps to realize she had no idea what she was doing. She had no one to ask for advice on how to plan a normal, non-Horde-like date.

The people passing by gave her a cautious look, likely spotting the anxious look on her face. She wasn’t going to give up though, not so soon, not *30 seconds* after she told Catra she’d handle it. Hope sparked in her when she finally spotted a woman she remembered had come back from the fake berry trip with Catra. Katya didn’t seem to have that much of a strong opinion of Adora. *(Has it really gotten to this point?)*

“Katya? Katya!” Adora jogged over to her, waving her arms desperately despite the older woman being a few yards away with the ability to see Adora perfectly fine.

Planning

The second that Katya spotted the loud and direct young woman charging her way she knew she’d regret whatever she was about

to do. She'd have half the town bombarding her with questions about the town's vogue person. What she said, what she asked, what she wanted.

And yet, Katya found herself endeared with the nervous and despaired rambling of the girl who was technically barely past her teenage years.

A date . She needed help planning one. And in the face of the crowd of nosey people gathering around her, Katya took the girl gently by the shoulder, leading her to the direction of her modest little home. It took a moment but eventually the two settled, Adora still fidgeting from the nerves and Katya sitting tensely in the presence of Adora.

It melted away the moment Katya asked, "What do you like to do?" and the answer she received was one of complete loss, *I… don't know.*

Well. That would definitely present a problem. "Do you know about things you *could* do?"

Katya watched the girl pause. She studied her a little further while she stared off into space, probably thinking.

'Adora' was well-built. Likely a product of being raised in the Horde, Katya assumed as she saw the similar, but also *different* way Catra was built. Catra, as heartbroken as she had been, ate

well. Especially after being introduced to the salmon traded with the nearby river village, she could be found snacking every now and then when she worked. Adora was strong, yes, but she looked too *lean* . Adora wasn't made to be lean, Catra was. Adora should have looked bulkier in some ways. Her cheeks weren't quite colored the way a pale girl like hers should be. She was reminded of the fact that this girl had thought Catra was *dead* .

She wondered if perhaps Grace was doing alright.

She was shaken out of the sudden, but common thought when Adora finally perked up with an audible, "Aha!"

"Yes?"

"I like punching things!"

That one made Katya stare with a bit of *I should have seen this coming* , and a lot of concern, "Yes… Catra seems to like that as well. Something a little more relaxing might work better though, right?" Adora got the final say in this after all. If it came down crashing and burning would it really be Katya's fault?

Adora pursed her lips and nodded in remembrance, "Oh, yeahh, she did say something about relaxing."

The older woman decided it might be best to simply start suggesting things instead, “Have you ever been to one of the nearby towns? Maybe see something new, or go out to eat something? Catra likes fish.” Yes, that was excellent. Adora could simply *choose* and Katya could get back to her embroidery.

Adora’s shifting eyes and fidgeting hands said otherwise. She was muttering something under her breath until she finally gave up and spoke loud enough for Katya to hear, nearly sweating, “Fish is the thing that comes from water, right?”

Oh. Katya’s lips parted slightly in surprise, her expression seemingly making Adora even more nervous. Watching the girl, it seemed like half of her wanted to run out the door, her knees unbending slightly in the act of getting up from her chair, and the other half was desperate to explain herself, her hands waving in front of her in a sort of bad reasoning- “No! No! I know what a fish is, of course! They taught us all that in the Horde, it’s just- I mean there are just so many animals- and they turn them into food- there was probably like 1% fish in ration bars, right? And Brightmoon has so many *other* foods and animals, it’s just so hard to keep track- I’ve been busy! Fish were- they’re unimportant- well actually you said Catra liked them so they’re *super* important-”

Katya slowly stood and placed a gentle hand on Adora’s wrist, keeping her from leaving but giving her the option of pulling away. Her gentle expression settled the blonde, and for a second Katya could spot the fear settling in Adora’s eyes. It was like taming a desperate, wild animal. It was ironic considering Catra herself had been less outwardly wild. Adora was the one pulling her hair out trying to keep track of so much new information that Katya

assumed she had never really processed. Information that Catra hadn't quite processed either.

A silent look of *it's okay* made itself present to Adora, and she finally took a moment to sit down in her chair and swallow down her rambling, "... Does she like the fish that's alive or the one that's cooked?"

Katya smiled. "She liked the cooked one. It's tasty to her. I can recommend some places with it on the menu- um those are like these papers that tell you what you can buy from the restaurant. Would you like that?"

Adora nodded enthusiastically. This planning stuff was turning out to be better than she had expected.

THE plan.

Adora was… adorable, to be frank. Catra knew since they were kids that the dork could be a hopeless romantic, but she was out of her element here in the 'real world'. Catra had half a mind to go out and help Adora plan the date… but she *had* told her to relax.

She settled deeper into her seat. Maybe she wanted to be spoiled a little.

Had that been what prompted Catra to suggest the idea of a date in the first place? She didn't know. Things with Adora could be weird and difficult, but weren't they always?

They just needed that extra push and Catra- scared as she was of winning over Adora only to lose her again- was done playing chicken like she had this past week. Like she had her entire life. *'You wanted this'* she reminded herself. And it was true. Perhaps it was the most honest Catra had been with herself in some time.

With that, a smirk grew alongside an idea. Sitting straighter up in her chair, Catra knew the more time she spent alone, the more this impulsive thought would grow.

She wouldn't give Adora a gentle push, she'd send her toppling over with a full-on shove.

Dress.

Ethan had only seen Catra walk into her store twice. The first time it was because she had gotten lost trying to find the hardware store (before realizing there wasn't one nearby and if there was it'd be out of stock) and the second time was when she walked in, grabbed a week's worth of clothes, and dumped what looked like a bag of stolen coins on the counter, gone in a blink.

This was the third time, and while he had now seen Catra in her own shop, between the two of them being the only people in the

room and Catra's quiet, unsure browsing, Ethan couldn't help but speak up.

"Are you looking for anything, Miss Catra?"

Catra's steps faltered. She wasn't quite facing the shopkeeper, but her tail twitched in contemplation. Her head tipped ever so slightly, but Ethan knew it was the closest he would get to acceptance. Catra seemed to be in a vulnerable state at the moment. But then again, when wasn't she?

Once he approached, Catra staying still in her spot, the two of them couldn't help but whisper, trying to maintain the silence of the store.

Ethan, for all his knowledge in fashion, had no idea what Catra wanted. People typically came in here spouting the same loving nonsense Catra had whispered to him, and they ended up with near the exact same thing every time. But Catra, as cliche as she was being right now, was also asking for something unique. Something *truly* unique, not what people claimed was unique when in reality all they left the store with was a yellow sundress.

It was a challenge that sent a thrill through Ethan's spine.

It's only the first date but I want something that'll knock her socks off- stars that sounds too much like something she'd say- but I still want to feel… nice, hot, *I guess.*

I'd go for a suit but I think that'll be too much for the dummy to handle she chuckled.

Catra heard Adora walk through the door and the first thing she noticed when she glanced up was that Adora was not, in fact, wearing her usual Horde clothing. The second thing she noticed was Adora's dumbstruck look.

"I uh, I didn't know you had other clothes," she had just been getting used to seeing Catra out of her Horde uniform and in more civilian-like clothes. This was too much.

"Not all of us can wear the exact same outfit for years, Adora," Catra laughed before the sound morphed into something more like a breathy, "I see you finally decided to go for something different, though."

Ethan was a sneaky little man and Catra would either get him back for this or never mention it because she was simply too appreciative of the suit Adora was wearing. She knew they typically worked the other way around but she found that even liking the feel and comfort of a suit like Adora's more, she still felt attractive in a more unfamiliar way.

It was nice. Exactly what she had asked of the clothing designer.

Taking a moment to appreciate each other, Adora finally sucked a nervous breath in and extended an arm out to Catra.

"Shall we?"

"We shall," Catra giggled. She knew nothing would be able to ruin this moment, no matter what it was that Adora had planned.

Watching the wonder light up in a customer's eyes was something Pequer always strode to achieve. When the blonde from earlier walked in again, this time with a stunning brunette on her arm and the both of them adequately dressed for the occasion, they knew it was time. Though Pequer was a professional in their craft, as many were in this town, they found that they never lost their love for seeing the tears rise up in someone's eyes.

This time though, it was like a blow to the heart to see the trembling of the brunette's hands as she threw herself into a teary embrace with the blonde. Something had been healed right there and then.

Sensing the moment to be too intimate to witness, Pequer exited the room silently, leaving the couple to whisper to each other in the dim room.

Catra could hardly believe her eyes when Adora brought her to this spot outside of Thaymor. She had explored the outside world on her own a bit, but she wondered how Adora knew she would have liked this. The date had had several phases starting with a place to eat and now they had somehow ended up *here* . She

took it all in. Adora would *stay* and now she was so *so* sure of it. Looking over at Adora and seeing the light and love reflecting off her eyes in a delicate dance of simple purity, Catra couldn't help but think Adora was the one giving her the push as she muttered between the two of them.

"Adora you know I've always wanted to…"

"Yeah, yeah I know… me too"

"I know"

"So?"

"So what?"

"What are you going to do about it?"

And Catra felt that *shove* , the almost cocky smirk adorning Adora's face in such a soft, soft way that had Catra falling hard and *fast* . So fast she was stumbling for purchase only found when Adora finally leaned in too.

Their kiss was slow and subtle and *inexperienced* like the way they would hold each other and whisper in the dark, when Adora

would run her fingers through Catra’s hair without restraint, and Catra would blush freely in the dark knowing Adora wouldn’t be able to see. But as Catra wrapped her arm around the back of Adora’s neck and Adora herself gripped Catra’s waist a little tighter, a little more desperately, their lips and entire beings pressed together a little more firmly, a little more sure as neither ever backed away fully when they needed a breath. *This* was it. *These* were the waves that they conjured up so often finally building up to a tsunami that left Catra breathless, and based on Adora’s own expressions she felt the same.

She was drowning.

And she loved it.

Chapter End Notes

ocean metaphors -> making out
Kind of a plotless chapter, but I also wasn't sure if the Catradora was sufficient so we get this before we move on (I'm stalling, okay?)
Do you know where Adora took Catra? Because I have no clue either. I have not and will never be loved in the way I'm making Adora love Catra here please help me I'm supposed to be studying political science but why do that when I can write this
also let me know if you like the mix of the earlier chapter's style and the more recent chapter style I tried to combine them a little
anyway love ya'll please don't forget me <3.

End Notes

I don't know how long this is going to be, and updates may be inconsistent but it will be finished, even if I don't think all of it makes sense.

Adora and Catra abandoned each other but they both needed the time separated, this gives them that but Taylor Swift form :)
Please let me know if you have any ideas for this, I have a sort of plan but nothing is set in stone.

I hope you like it so far, comments and kudos are appreciated greatly, and constructive criticism is welcome!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!